Growing Up Horde

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

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F/F, F/M, M/M

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Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora, Catra (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra)

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Growing Up Horde

by Faded_Glory

Summary

(A companion piece to Tapestry of Time) Life is full of so many small moments, that define who we are and who will become.

Notes

This is a collection of short stories set before, between and after my main series 'Tapestry of Time.' I suggest you read, Kingdom of Ash, Kingdom of Stars and Kingdom of Blood before.

Junior Years

The play yard in the nursery wing of the Infirmary was as sterile and devoid of color as the walls within. Every piece of equipment in the nursery serves a function. To either educate their minds, to improve their physical capabilities, or to keep them clean and healthy.

The play yard is mostly covered in dirt or cement, with a sturdy steel dome shaped jungle gym, attached to a military style play structure. Its many structural metal poles embedded into the hard unforgiving surface along its circumference, with a sand pit beneath. With several small children in gray jumper's climbing and hanging from the bars, a few sat in the sand digging with their bare hands. Another sturdy metal structure that resembled more of a military obstacle course then play equipment stood beside the jungle gym. Consisting of a tall rock wall, the hand holds are made of molded dull gray plastic. Crude hanging ropes with knots drifting in the hot breeze from a trapeze bar and a swinging bridge a few meters away.

A small army of tiny children were scattered over the structure, all in different colored jumper's. Climbing up the ropes, the wall and chasing each other up and down the swinging bridge. While others raced around the cement at the edge of the sand pit, screaming and laughing. While a handful of caregiver's in white scrubs, holding clipboards stood nearby. Taking notes of each child's dexterity, strength and fine motor skills. There were no smiles or encouragement from the nursery officer's, they did not show any kind of affection for the little kids under their charge. Such frivolous emotions served no purpose. They were all clinical and detached. As the children were merely products destined to become soldiers. The officer's tasked only to make sure these new

recruits were strong and capable before transferring them to the barracks.

The Horde was a military machine that functioned precisely how Hordak had intended. Order and purpose was the cornerstone of his regime's conditioning. Everyone served a function and strove for excellence. Because Lord Hordak did not tolerate failure or uselessness. The consequences for Soldier's who proved themselves unworthy were deadly. Fear of punishment or death was a supreme method to maintain control over his army. One he used rather liberally for the last decade or more.

A few yards away near the chain link fence. A long serpent shaped tunnel, made of massive industrial rubber tires took up the length of the yard. The rubber base sunk deep into the cement tarmac that framed the large sand pit.

The afternoon was hot and muggy, steam was hovering close to the cement. A small girl, with honey blonde hair tied up in a ponytail, barely four years old. Had tucked herself out of the heat and into the shade of the rubber tunnel. Keeping herself entertained with a sharp stone, by scratching its edge on the cement beneath her. Drawing contentedly, as she hummed a nonsensical tune only she knew. Her hair hung wet to her shoulders with sweat, round cheeks rosy from the heat.

She never cried or complained about having to be outside, being cooped up in the nursery was worse. The air inside was stuffy and smells sour, she preferred to be outside. Ignoring the rambunctious screams and laughter of the kids surrounding her. So focused on her drawing, she vaguely heard their caregiver's beginning role call, to lead them back inside. As several delicate white butterflies fluttered into the dank, musty shade of the tunnel, landing on her crude markings.

"Pretty…" Adora breathed, watching the tiny creatures floating in the air and landing around her now splayed fingers over the

drawing. As she pressed her palms flat to the ground. Having discarded her rock in the recesses of the tunnel. She watched the butterflies dancing in the air, following them with sweet blue eyes full of wonder. As they fluttered up on the hot breeze towards the chain link fence, slipping through the links effortlessly into the sprawling compound beyond.

"No…pretties ... .stay!" Adora pleaded, crawling out of the tunnel, dashing for the fence, desperate to watch them until they disappeared into the shadow's of the building's beyond the fence. Her days were dull, full of routine and controlled play. So she could be tested and ranked accordingly to the other kids. Rarely, did anything unexpected happen. Adora craved more excitement, but would never voice her needs. Quiet and accepting of the boredom she dealt with everyday. But now the thrill of adventure was taking root inside of her, she wanted to follow those tiny, magical creatures…see what lay beyond…

Just as her pudgy hands hit the chain, her fingers gripping the links and shaking them roughly in frustration at being contained. A cloud of sparkles appeared just beyond the fence. A portion of fence near the ground was badly rusted and with a high pitched groan. The links began to bend upward as if being pushed by the wind, creating a hole in the fence just large enough for her. Adora's eyes widened in amazement at the sudden escape offered to her. With a determined nod, she crawled through the hole. Her jumper near her hip caught on the sharp, broken metal links as she slipped through. Tearing her clothes and leaving a few gray threads behind. With a cry of glee, Adora scampered after the butterflies. Disappearing into the twisting alley's of the Fright Zone, as they led her onward to her destiny.

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Her slumber had been so long, so deep. It was as if she had been dragged down to the very depths of the ocean. Left to wait in an infinite world of nothingness. Where time no longer had meaning, trapped in a peaceful limbo of her dreams. The extreme amount of effort and determination needed to rise back to the surface to awareness, seemed insurmountable. As she struggled to wake up…to open her eyes…that were still so very heavy…closing them as swiftly as she had opened them. Barely comprehending what was happening.

Her first memory was of blue eyes…that were so beautiful… like the wide Savannah sky on a warm clear day. Staring down at her in pure, innocent wonder. Mesmerized by the sight of her, staring so softly down at her, as if she was the most amazing treasure they had ever seen. Unable to stay awake for long, her eyes closed against her will, dragging her away into the darkness with a frustrated growl.

“Hello, there..” A sweet voice, calling to her, drawing her away from the dark depths. “Come…back…kitty..”

The tenderness of her words drew the kitten's attention instantly and she stubbornly opened her eyes again, refusing to allow that strange sleep to swallow her again.

As she slowly came aware of her surroundings yet again. Blinking rapidly to clear the fog of forced sleep from her mind. Her eyes once again became transfixed upon those clear blue eyes, staring down at her so tenderly. Slowly taking in more of her little savior’s visage. Long, honey blonde hair, curtained a round, dirty face. Small hands gripped the sides of her metal cradle. Her eyes were drawn upon the small, white butterflies perched upon the lip of her cradle. Their delicate wings fluttered, eager to be in flight again.

Then she lost her ability to focus, as her vision blurred with tears. Her small body began to ache, the numbness of hibernation fading into a throbbing pain. That coursed through her on a bone deep level that had her now wailing in agony. Large dark ears

pinned back against her head, hissing and trembling. As raw panic washed over her. Her chest clenched as she struggled to breathe, not understanding what was happening to her. Having no memory of how she got trapped in this box, that was now hurting her so horribly. Her limbs refused to move, still frozen in place across her tiny chest. Fingers locked in a curled position around her blanket, clutched under her button nose. She was so scared and confused, instinctively she knew that her blanket was comfort…but the scents that once soothed her were gone…replaced by the sharp smell of ozone. That stung her nose, she hissed and released her grip upon the fabric with a wail of pain. That was so sharp and piercing, it echoed throughout the damp earthen chamber. The blanket slipped away, to pool along her side. As she began to shiver violently, teeth chattering as her body continued to thaw.

"It's ok…I'm here…I'll make it better." The urgency and genuine concern from the strange blonde girl's voice was instantly soothing. As the little girl crawled into the kitten's resting place without fear, snuggling down behind her and pulled her small furry body against her chest.

"What's your name?...My names Adora." She asked, softly. Tucking her chin over the kitten's delicate shoulder. Hot breath whispering gently against the shell of the kitten's ear.

"Kaira…" The kitten whimpered through chattering teeth, sniffing curiously at the new scent that now surrounded her. It was gentle, tickling her nose like a soft breeze. The warmth of the new larger body, hugging her so delicately. Was a soothing balm to her aching body. As much as this girl's sweet smell calmed the panic that was once storming inside of her. A soft purr of contentment rumbled from deep in her chest. Closing her eyes without fear and basking in the security of Adora's embrace as the pain of waking finally began to fade.

"Catra…that's pretty." Adora smiled softly, her little voice was slurring as complete and utter exhaustion crashed over her. Her eye's growing heavy now that she has found a warm soft place to lie down. After hours of being lost in these ruins, wandering alone

and terrified. She allows herself to finally relax. Lulled by the kitten's gentle purr, she feels safe and protected, hidden in this tiny metal box with her new friend. It was then the butterflies took their leave, dancing away into the stillness of the chamber. Their mission is complete.

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First Year of Junior Training…

The season's had passed and they were no longer considered babies but junior cadets. School and training was going to start soon…and one day they would become full fledged Horde soldiers. But today, they were moving out of the nursery and into their new home in the barracks.

Adora stood in the doorway to the sleeping area of the nursery, staring up at Shadow Weaver's looming figure before her. The sorceress leaned forward just enough to cup the blonde girl's cheek in a tender, motherly fashion. Yet, still maintaining a silently dominant pose over the small child.

Adora couldn't help the wide smile of pride that glowed upon her round face. Dressed in her first cadet uniform, a white t-shirt with red sleeves and gray pants with darker knee patches and red sneakers. Shadow Weaver had taken her aside. Giving her a firm pep talk about her expectations. Expressing to Adora how she had seen great potential in her and knew she could rise to the challenge ahead and would not disappoint her.

Adora was so wrapped up in the Sorceress praise, she never noticed. How Shadow Weaver had bluntly ignored Catra and did not offer the scared kitten any sort of reassurance. Leaving little Catra shaking in the corner of the nursery, hopeful eyes slowly

dimming, that Shadow Weaver would offer her the same motherly attention. As the masked sorceress never even acknowledges her existence. Her focus unwavering from Adora. Disappointed and hurt, Catra slowly bowed her head and waited for Adora to return to her side. She had dutifully dressed out of her yellow jumper and into her new cadet uniform as well. She had also been proud of her gray pants and red leotard. Had wanted to show off her new status as a cadet to Shadow Weaver. Now, she just felt like her effort didn't matter….that she was invisible.

"Hey….Adora…" Catra had called, timidly after the Sorceress had left. A quiet entreaty for the blonde to acknowledge her. Adora turned from the open doorway, where she had been watching her mentor depart. Her smile broadened with fond affection as she rushed back to Catra's side. Taking her hand, as they stood together waiting for the next chapter in their lives to begin.

Moving into the barracks from the nursery was scary…but exciting! Catra never let go of Adora's hand when they left the nursery wing of the infirmary. The last year spent in the nursery, she had come to count on Adora to take care of her. Her trust in the adults there, had been quickly discarded. As they never put in the effort to truly understand her like Adora did. She didn't have much faith that the adults charged to train them in the barracks would be any better.

But she had Adora and that was all that mattered.

Adora had become everything to her…her entire world…the thought of not having her at her side was terrifying. So she tried very hard not to dwell upon such terrible thoughts.

Now both girls clutched their respective blankets to their chests. The only item they were allowed to take with them. Holding hands, as they followed along in a small line of other Nursery graduates. At the head of their little parade was a Senior cadet, dressed in a white shirt with orange accents and black pants and

combat boots. The kind looking senior cadet had been ordered to lead them to their bunk room in the infantry barracks.

Adora was focused on staying in line, pulling Catra, who shuffled obediently behind her. Catra was on high alert the entire time, eyes wide and ears perked upward. As she took in the long, dimly lit corridors of the base. The steady buzz of the overhead lights an irritating static in her sensitive ears. Sniffing the air and chirping nervously at every scent. Her lashing tail, stiffened and fluffed in fright, when the vents thundered and groaned with a burst of hot air. Adora steeled her expression, just as afraid of the sudden loud sound but refusing to show it. She put on a brave face, as she felt Catra's claws unsheathe and prick the palm of her hand.

"It's ok…I'm right here. " She smiled brightly over her shoulder. Alway quick with positive reassurance that everything was going to be alright. Which as always, was contagious and Catra blinked slowly at Adora. As a low comforting purr thrummed from deep inside her tiny chest. Nothing bad would ever happen to her again, as long as she has Adora by her side.

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Settling into the routine of living in the barracks was different for every kid. But that first night…was the worst for everyone. Adora had snuggled with Catra in her lower bunk, just as they had done every night in the Nursery. But Catra just couldn't fall asleep with so many new smells and scents surrounding her. She was on edge and restless. Not wanting to disturb Adora's slumber. Catra had slunk out of her arms and climbed up high where she felt safer. Now, Catra was huddled up on her top bunk, wedged tight against the wall. Knees pulled up to her chest, dressed in her dull gray underclothes. Struggling not to cry, as she sniffled and whimpered softly. Adora was fast asleep in the bunk below, Catra had silently argued with herself. Desperately wanting to wake up the blonde,

so she could reassure and comfort her. But she was also rather stubborn and wanted to prove to herself that she was strong. That Adora didn't have to coddle her anymore. She was regretting that decision as the wee hours' of the night passed in sleepless misery.

Her glowing cat eyes warily scanned the dark interior of the bunkroom. Ears twitched at every sound. Reviewing the afternoon and evening hours, she had waisted by being aloof. She had been far too shy to introduce herself to the other kids, when they got there. But as always, Adora took charge. Holding her hand tight and pulling her around the room as she got to know everyone in their squadron. As soon as Catra could wiggle her hand out of Adora's grasp, she retreated up high onto her bunk and stayed there. Watching the other kids, visiting and playing games around the room. Getting to know each other, while she had purposefully set herself apart from them. Her turbulent last year in the nursery had made her wary. She wanted friends, but kids and adults didn't really like her…so didn't like them…at least that's what she told herself.

Adora would cast her concerned looks from time to time, but didn't push for her to come down. Knowing how skittish she could be and if she got nervous or scared. Her claws would come out, so it was better if she eased into this new life on her own terms. At lights out, Adora finally managed to coax her down.

With the rest of the kids settled in their bunks, Catra felt safe enough to move down from her perch. But the security she had come to depend on in Adora's arms at night, had not come. Disheartened and frustrated, she had retreated back up high.

So now, Catra was back on her top bunk, curled with her blanket tucked under her nose. Washing her sense of smell in the comforting scent, of both her and Adora. As she listened to Kyle cry himself to sleep on the top bunk across the aisle from hers.

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It had taken several days for Catra to relax, as she subtly marked every inch of her and Adora’s bunk, rubbing her cheeks everywhere. Flicking her tail in a few spots along the various corridors they traveled on a daily basis, scenting their routes. To the gym and the mess hall, the locker room and shower’s. Enough to finally settle her anxiety about her new environment.

As the daily routine of cadet life settled both of their fears, Catra became more playful and Adora welcomed her spunky antic’s with her bright smile’s and fond touches. They had managed to find a new normal here in the barracks, but the cornerstone of their relationship would never change.

Because nothing bad could ever happen to them as long as they were together.

Catra was crouched low on her top bunk, haunches wiggling in anticipation as her tail lashed. Her ears perked up as she heard her bunkmates' laughter, echoing down the hall outside their bunkroom. She focused on the sounds, pinpointing Adora’s bright, energetic voice among the cacophony of sounds.

Her pupils dilated, as the door hissed open and the first few kids entered the bunkroom. She watched them file in one by one, growing more and more excited. When the familiar blonde ponytail came into view, she pounced!

“Ooof!” Adora expelled all the air from her tiny lungs, as she was propelled to the floor on her back by Catra’s sudden weight on her chest.

“What the heck!” Lonnie exclaimed, jumping away from Adora as she was tackled to the ground right in front of her. Lonnie was dressed in a similar uniform as Adora. Her tight curls of dark hair shiny from getting out of the shower, just before being released for lunch break.

“Feeling better?’ Adora grinned, brushing a hand down Catra’s wild mane of hair.

Catra had struggled to wake up this morning, feeling weird and overly tired. Her body had ached and Staff Sargent Lazlo had given her the morning off to recoup. Stating she had pushed herself too hard yesterday and needed extra rest. But she was proud of her fitness stat’s yesterday, even though Shadow Weaver never acknowledged her improvement. Catra had swallowed her disappointment, assuring herself that one day. She would prove herself to the Sorceress.

Now she felt full of energy and she had missed Adora!

“Hey, Adora…let’s play chase!” She giggled, leaping off Adora’s chest and yanking her up onto her feet. Only to flee out of the sliding doors of the bunkroom squealing in delight out into the corridor.

“Catra!” Adora raced after her, their lunch break was almost over and if they were not in the line up to head to class they would both be in trouble. But Catra never seemed to care about obeying the rules…it was so hard to get the feline to take training seriously…

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Their first cold season in the barracks had been absolutely miserable so far. The nights were cold and their thin blankets did little to keep them warm. Their underclothes were heavier,

consisting of gray wool long sleep pants and white fleece long sleeve shirts. But they still provided little protection when the temperature dropped to below freezing. The infantry barracks was a housing and train facility compound, on the far north east sector of the Fright Zone. Built in a geometric cluster of simple tin and steel framed buildings surrounded by various cement training yards, framed by tall chain link fences.

The heat coming from the vents was pathetic, as the barracks were far from the forge and didn't get the bulk of the heat. That the core tower's of the base received. That housed Hordak, Shadow Weaver and the Force Captain's. The cadets of Red Squad were resilient though and rather resourceful. Pulling together as a team to create warmer, more comfortable places to sleep.

They had learned about constructing temporary, shelter's from local materials in their survival class to protect them from the elements. Putting that knowledge to use, they had rallied as a team. Creating makeshift enclosures out of their bunks to hold in their body heat, by draping thread bare tarps scavenged from the scrapyard during their free time. Now three cadet's cuddled on the lower mattress of half of the bunks, under all three of their blankets. Able to keep warm and stay cozy the whole night through.

Sargent Lazlo had commended them on their ingenuity and never reprimanded them. So they all felt proud at what they had accomplished as a unit so far that first year.

The wind was howling outside, whistling through the tin walls. But it was warm and the slight weight of the combined blankets was comforting. Catra basked in the familiar scents of her best friends. Curled up on Adora's thin mattress, with her arms draped over Tama's stomach. Loosely holding Adora's waist with her fingertips, as the blonde was curled up against the fox hybrid on the other side. The blonde's hands rested tenderly on Catra's upper arms, finger's lightly tracing the stripes hidden under her long sleeve shirt. As Tama's soft voice lulled them both to sleep, her smaller body sandwiched softly between them.

“Once upon a time, there was a Gold-tree and a Silver-Tree that grew on either side of an ancient river, deep inside the Whispering Woods.” Tama began her tale, as she always did before bed.

The soft sounds of the other cadet’s rustling, as they got comfortable in their enclosures nearby. Intent on listening quietly to Tama’s bedtime story, as they all did every night. Catra would never admit it, but she loved this time the most and looked forward to it every day. Tama’s tales were always full of wonder and adventure. So much better than those scary princess stories, Shadow Weaver would tell them.

“The two tree’s had grown from saplings, not able to talk to each other as the river was far too wide for their voices to carry. So they merely watched each other, mature and grow more beautiful as the eon’s past…for a time it was enough. They both craved more, each one had become very lonely… ” Tama continued.

“What’s an eon..” Kyle's croaking voice inquired from beyond their makeshift tent.

“Shut it Kyle!” Lonnie reprimanded, as his question had interrupted the flow of Tama’s story.

“Sorry…” Kyle moaned.

Tama giggled, “In time the two tree’s figured out a way to communicate with each other, they would wave their branches, when one of them was looking in their direction. Their elegant gold and silver leaves, shimmering in the breeze like a silent welcome to the other tree. They were still alone on their side of the river bank, but they no longer felt lonely.

Their connection to each other was fleeting but it was enough, at least for a while. Time passed…as their roots continued to grow deeper, crawling beneath the river bed, moving ever closer to…. ” Tama continued as the wind howled, her soft. sweet voice soothing them all. As the story would eventually end, Tama’s and Catra’s purr’s would lull everyone to sleep.

Their little homemade tents didn't last longer than a few weeks, though. Until an older squad, that was bunked in the barracks nearby. Had broken into their quarter's and tore them apart while they were in class. Leaving the tarps, shredded and unuseable on the floor. It had been their first taste of how brutally unfair life outside the nursery could be. It was heartbreaking but necessary to learn. They had no way to find out who had done it and were still far too young and inexperienced in combat to retaliate. It had been Adora's first test, as their leader. To keep them under control. She had calmed the more violent and hotheaded squadmates who wanted to seek revenge, such as Atila and Catra. Explaining with infinite patience, as she blocked their bunk room doors refusing to let them leave. As Catra prowled and Atila stomped his feet in fury before her. Reiterating how they had no idea who it was and that blindly attacking another squad without evidence would only start a war. One they couldn't win…yet. As the others who were scattered around the room, cleaning up the tarps. Had turned to her for reassurance and comfort. Someone had violated their safe space and they were all scared. So she had promised them that she would speak to Staff Sergeant Lazlo. In the hopes that a ranked officer would investigate and discipline those involved.

He had merely shrugged and expressed to her that what they had done was non-regulation and taking it up to his superiors would only land the squad with punishment. So she had sought out Shadow Weaver next, the sorceress had always listened to her, looked out for her. She would protect them?

Shadow Weaver had reprimanded her for showing weakness by seeking others out to solve her problems. It had been a harsh lesson, as her tattling to Lazlo and Shadow Weaver quickly spread through the barracks. She had yet to understand the Horde Cadet code…that what happens in the barracks stays in the barracks. The Cadets governed themselves within those walls. The next few months would be a test of survival for her squad. As noble as her intentions were to defend her bunkmates she had placed a target

on their backs instead. It was her first, most cruel lesson. As her squadmates were relentlessly bullied by the older's cadets as retribution for what she had done. While she went unscathed, as Shadow Weaver's golden girl, no one would ever mess with her.

She learned not to involve adults in her problems. From then on, she dealt with the other squads picking on her bunkmates or stealing their things personally. She protected her friends, using any means necessary to get her point across. That she would not tolerate anyone hurting her bunkmates…especially her Catra!

Knowing she was protected, because they all feared Shadow Weaver's wrath and they couldn't retaliate against her, so she used that to her advantage.

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Season's pass…

Catra's feet hurt…her back ached from having to stand at attention for hours. This had been her punishment for disobeying orders, by breaking formation on their way to gym. To follow Octavia to the Forge, where she had disposed of Tama's body. Adora had found her crying in the bunkroom and had tried to sneak her back to the gym only to get caught halfway there by Staff Sergeant Lazlo. Who had been headed there to check on the squad after he had filed his report.

Catra glanced to her left, Adora was standing at attention beside her sharing the punishment. She felt guilty that Adora had gotten

in trouble because of her, but she was also very happy to have her by her side. She was barely holding in her grief, sniffling softly and swallowing her tears refusing to let them fall and look weak. As they had been ordered to stand in the hall outside their bunkroom. Their punishment was on full display to every cadet walking past, who were heading to their own bunk rooms in the barracks. Adora shuffled closer, hearing now valiantly Catra was trying not to cry. As soon as their shoulders were touching, she linked her pinky finger with Catra's.

Catra gasped, refusing to look at her and acknowledge the small act of comfort. Keeping her eyes facing ahead. But she welcomed it, curling her pinky ever tighter to Adora's. A silent act of care and solidarity, between them.

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Junior Years: Part Two

Chapter Notes

Thank you to all who have left Kudo's. I appreciate it!!!!

Second year…

The sudden rustle of the shower curtain being thrown aside, startled Adora. Who yelped and spun around, she was naked and at her most vulnerable. Raising her fists to defend herself, her heart slamming in her chest. It was not the first time a cadet had gotten jumped in the communal shower. It was a known public space for cadets to seek retribution and retaliate against others. There really wasn't a safe place to relax and let down your guard while in the barracks. Adora was getting used to that. Needing to always be alert, even when asleep and able to fight at a moment's notice.

"Hey, Adora!" Catra's impish smile greeted her, as she turned abruptly from the cold spray of the shower. Finding a soaking wet and dripping young cat girl, grinning at her from just beyond the cramped stall. Her long brunette mane was plastered down her back, long tail snapping playfully. Catra wore only a soggy white towel wrapped around her waist and a competitive gleam in her eyes.

"First one to the locker room, wins. Loser has to give the winner their ration bar tonight at dinner!" Catra declared, spinning on her heels and dashing away. Her wet long chestnut brown hair, flipping like a wet cape and spraying Adora in the face. Unintentionally taunting her even more, as she was forced to wipe away the moisture with her hand.

"Catra, No! Wait Up, That's not fair, you're cheating!" Adora howled, quickly turning the knob to shut off the water. Reaching

up to the tile, half wall and snapping her own towel around her small chest. As the loud vibration of the plumbing, sealing the water in the pipes thundered through the now empty room. Adora bolted after Catra at top speed.

Everything was a game to Catra…she was always racing and climbing and making up little competitions. Most of the time Adora went along with it, enjoyed it even. Sometimes she won, sometimes she lost…but Adora had more responsibility now, more pressure not to screw up and disappoint Shadow Weaver. Which she knew was starting to affect her friendship with Catra, who never seemed to do anything right in the eyes of their guardian. So now Adora was starting to question where and when it was appropriate for them to play around and so as not get into trouble. Becoming vigilant as to how to act, how to speak and how not to get on Shadow Weaver's bad side! She did not want what happened in the Black Garnet Chamber to ever happen again.

"Grab her tail!" A frantic voice shouted from down the short corridor that connected the communal showers to the junior cadet locker room.

Adora had just left the showers and was rushing down the short hall. When she heard the taunting, echoing from further ahead. She lunged into a full on sprint towards the locker's now, her heart in her throat and fury boiling in her gut. As Catra's hiss and frightened yowl of distress exploded from just ahead.

The older cadet's had made catching Catra's tail a daily sport. Always laying in wait, ready to ambush her whenever they caught her alone. She found two much older cadets. Wearing the uniform of the indigo squad, pinning Catra against the wall just before the open doorway of their locker room.

It was infuriating to see, Catra had almost made it to safety. Dressed in nothing but a towel, her bare willow thin chest heaving

in fear. The kitten felt vulnerable and scared. Her ears were pinned back and her mane was standing wildly around her thin shoulder's as her hackles were up. Glaring furiously up at the two young men, caging her in. The young magicat hated having to shower, for this very reason. The older cadet's hunted and tormented her relentlessly lately. Not just because they found riling her up humorous. Laughing and making her feel weak as she hissed and spit, as if she posed absolutely no threat to them. They liked to catch her after the shower's cause her fur would fluff out and look weird as it dried. Make her a prime target for teasing if she gets caught by other cadet's in this very hall, when in transit from the communal showers to the junior locker room to get dressed.

"Leave her alone!" Adora shouted, tearing her own towel off her body and twirling it in between her two hands to create a makeshift whip. She didn't care that she was now totally naked in front of two teens.

She was a child and didn't know enough to be embarrassed! She was furious and determined to show these bullies a lesson that they would not forget. Messing with Catra meant dealing with Adora!

The boys both turned, stunned for a second to be confronted by a rage fueled little girl. The next second, Adora snapped the wet towel into each of their faces. Her aim was deadly and accurate, from practicing with slinging stones with Catra in the Scrap Yard.

The boys ran off, howling and clutching their eyes that were now stinging horribly.

Adora grinned triumphantly, hands on her bare hips. Blue eyes blazing with pride at her victory, as the two bullies ran off. Oblivious to the Magicat now gawking at her nudity, red faced and completely dumbfounded that she would be so bold. To forsake her modesty for the sake of running those thugs off.

Catra had yet to understand that Adora was a completely selfless person who would sacrifice anything…everything...to protect her… to save everyone she loved.

Shadow Weaver floated out of the locker room, her shadows falling ominously over Catra. Catra sensed the sudden threat behind her, shivered and instantly cringed. She never even looked back, scampering away on all fours as fast as her legs could carry her. Adora stood her ground, frozen in place. Standing nude and shivering, before the glowering white stare of her Guardian.

"Have some self respect, child. Put on your towel." Shadow Weaver snarled, pointing down at the discarded wet towel on the hall floor.

"Yes, Shadow Weaver." Adora whimpered, snatching up the towel and wrapping it around herself hastily. As a powerful wave of fear washed over her, never had she seen the Sorceress look so wrathful towards her.

(Delicious...) A cruel whisper, tickling in the back of Shadow Weaver's mind. Pushing her rage and displeasure to new heights. Then Shadow Weaver lunged out, pinching Adora's earlobe and guided her into the locker room roughly.

"Adora…what are you thinking? You are a Squad Leader, you can not humiliate yourself in front of older cadets." Shadow Weaver was livid.

"They were picking on Catra. I had no weapons to fight back with, I had to improvise?" Adora began to explain, then cried out in pain. As Shadow Weaver's finger's pinched sharply on the tender lobe of her ear. Forcing her to skip frantically to keep up to the taller woman's longer, agitated stride.

"Do not give me excuses! I shall not tolerate my protege, acting so undignified! It is obvious that Savage Animal has been a bad influence upon you. Catra is not worth you losing what meager

amount of respect you have managed to earn among the other squads." Shadow Weaver growled, releasing her ear once she had led Adora in front of her locker. What remained of Red Squad in the locker room, cowered behind their locker door's seeking to make themselves smaller and less of a target.

"Get Dressed! Then come to my chambers, we need to have a serious talk about Catra!" Shadow Weaver huffed, shaking her head and departed in a flurry of angry shadows.

Adora stood, blinking in absolute terror, as she obediently opened her locker. Struggling to swallow the lump of dread forming in her throat. As she got dressed on auto pilot, her mind spinning at the cruel turn this day had taken. Catra had abandoned her, ran as soon as she could…leaving Adora to her fate. Honestly, Adora couldn't fault her for it, with how Shadow Weaver seemed to target her…always scolding Catra and punishing her over every little thing. But it still hurt…that Catra wouldn't even try to protect her…from Shadow Weaver. Like she had for her in the Black Garnet Chamber.

It was in the dead hours of the night, when everyone in the bunk room was fast asleep. When Catra heard a small, pathetic whimper issuing from beneath her bunk. Followed by a sharp cry, quickly silenced by a moan of discomfort. The soft sounds of distress, had the kitten snapping her eyes open instantly. Everyone of the kids in the bunkroom had nightmares from time to time. But the drowsy grunts and rustling of Adora fighting amid the throes of a nightmare. Were sounds Catra was attuned to. She was in action within seconds, usually she had no idea what horrible event during the day had set off Adora's current night terrors. But today, she knew what had caused this bad dream. The guilt was crushing. Forcing her to confront her cowardice, she had run off and left her best friend to endure Shadow Weaver's wrath all alone. They had made a promise to each other just last year, that they would protect one another. She needed to make it right.

Slipping out of her blanket and crawling to the edge of her bunk, she swung herself down to the floor. Then promptly crawled into Adora's bunk, ducking the thrashing limbs as Adora fought off her dream attacker. Catra was by no means accustomed to dealing with Adora's unconscious violence, her dream fighting was infrequent and had only started within the last year.

"Adora…" Catra hissed, pouncing on the blonde girl's chest and attempting to grapple her wrists. Receiving a knee to the crotch and a fist glancing painfully off the side of her left ear. Before she managed to pin Adora's legs between her thighs, straddling the blonde's waist and holding her thrashing wrists above her head.

"Owwwww." Catra groaned, her sensitive ear was now throbbing and ringing from the hit.

"No….stop….no more…please…let me go….please…." Adora whimpered.

Catra's heart ached, knowing from personal experience what kind of 'instruction' Shadow Weaver had delivered upon Adora after their encounter in the locker room.

"Adora." Catra pleaded, softly. Not wanting to be too loud and wake the other's.

"I will do better…I'll do anything…I'll " Adora shuddered, then gasped as she awoke with a start.

Finding Catra hovering above her, eyes wide and searching her own for assurance. That she was awake and not going to continue to attack her.

"I'm awake…I'm awake." Adora muttered, heat rising to her cheeks. Worried about what kind of humiliating disturbance she had created in her sleep.

Catra sighed in relief, letting go of her wrists. Catra settled down upon her chest, tail curling protectively around Adora's arm, a soothing purr vibrating from her furry chest. Her warmth and

slight pressure of her body pressed up against her along with the soothing thrum of her purr, Adora’s residual fear faded instantly.

Adora sighed deeply, as her arms holding Catra's small frame, now snuggled up on her chest. As every muscle loosened and her thoughts calmed as she listened to her best friends purr. It wasn’t an apology per say, but it was how Catra communicated her affection. Catra hated seeing her suffer and would do whatever was needed to take care of her in the aftermath of Shadow Weaver’s temper. Just as Adora took care of her, every time she had to endure the Sorceress's wrath.

They kept their promise, as best they could…and it was enough…

The full fury of the hot season was upon them once again. Laps in the morning in their training yard were tolerable. But the rest of the day, dealing with the sweltering humidity, bleeding off the cement and perspiring on the metal walls inside the barracks was gross. The sour smell of sweat and rot clung to every hybrid’s nose like a foul skin, never clearing away even after the evening showers.

The mess hall was always packed this time of year, since all the daily highlights of the Senior trails would be broadcast over the evening meal. Catra hated eating in the mess, it was loud and far too many smells to deal with. But she endured the discomfort. Like all the rest of the young cadets, watching the trails was something they looked forward to every year. It was far more entertaining than having to listen to the Hordes, endless news feeds from the front lines, dispersed with short meaningful commercials that promoted the Hordes ideology. Demonizing the princesses, by showing clips of their chaotic magic destroying Horde troops and cities from the times of the first Princess Alliance. When Hordak had first clashed with the royalty of this planet, pushing their armies back into the Whispering Woods and the Kingdom of Snows. As the Horde conqued the Scorpion Kingdom. Setting into place the future borders of the Fright Zone

and their home…the monstrously large base built from the remains of his clone battalion's space ships.

Promoting the princesses as heartless destroyer's who hated anyone and anything that was not like them. The Eight Kingdom's had wanted to eradicate the clones, but Hordak was a superior being. He was able to rally his men, build up his armies and protect his people from their unjust reign. It was because of him, that they had a home, food to eat and purpose to carry on his fight. So that one day they would be free of the Etherian Royal line and build a prosperous future full of light and equality for all.

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Third Year…

The largest of the day moons was setting beyond the tower's of the Fright Zone. Taking with it the majority of the light, allowing the rest of Etheria's smaller moons to shine through the chemical red glare. The upper sky was slowly fading into the deeper indigo hues of approaching dusk. The shadows cast by the hulking buildings were crawling over the barracks. Soon the outdoor lamps would turn on. To attempt to illuminate what they could as night fell.

"STAY DOWN!" Atila roared, dressed in just his under clothes of a gray tank top and loose shorts. His black hide glistened with sweat, short dark mane standing up like a mohawk down the back of his thick head. His hulking body lurching forward. As he

backhanded Catra into the chain link fence in their training yard out back of their bunkroom. The cat girl's red and white, sleeveless tunic was covered in dirt. Her gray shorts stained with rust on her backside from colliding with the chain link fence, several times before.

Catra cried out in frustration and pain, as her small feline body collided once more with the fence. The links absorbed the impact of her small frame, rattling as she once again fell onto all fours before the powerful bulk of the Tauran boy. Who was glowering down at her from a few yards away. He was three times Catra's size, his dark brown eyes rolling with barely held in aggression. His horn points were capped, with rubber nubs, having nearly gored a fellow cadet a few season's back in a fit of rage. Balling his thick hands into fists at his sides, while his brown eyes glowered menacingly down at the sprawled magicat at his feet. Atila was frustrated and barely keeping himself under control…he did not want to hurt her…but damn it she was stubborn and so unbelievably feral…he didn't think he could hold back much longer…he was already bleeding from several good scratches along his arms.

Catra snarled, her brunette mane fluffed and wild around her face and shoulders.

"Give it back!" She exploded from the ground, dashing under Atila's wildly swinging arm and leaping up upon Tauran's back yet again. Her claws latched onto the larger boy's broader shoulders, as the young bull howled in pain. As her claws sunk deep in his dark leather hide. Her finger claws latching onto his shoulders and toe claws sinking into his hips, hanging on and riding him. As he spun and bucked like a wild beast.

"What the hell are you talking about!" He bellowed, spinning in a circle and slamming Catra into the heavy iron back door of their bunkroom with a resounding clang.

Catra groaned, but hung on. As the hollow sound of her body hitting the metal vibrated both outside and inside the tin building.

“I made that ‘shiny’ special for Adora and now it’s gone! I caught you looking at it this morning before breakfast…I know it was you!” Catra hissed. A ‘Shiny’ was a term junior cadet’s used for homemade badges they made for each other. To show gratitude, or affection. They had been to several award ceremonies where Soldiers were given medals of honor, or New Force Captains were given their badges of command. It is a glorious event, full of fanfare and celebration.

Atila sucked at making stuff and she knew he liked Sara, so he was her prime suspect.

Catre snarled, losing control and allowing her instincts to take over. Lunging with her canines. Biting Atilla’s neck, hard. His howl of acute pain was so satisfying to Catra. As the warm, salty blood oozed from the puncture wounds. Flowing into her mouth. Instinctively, she growled and latched on harder to his thick neck. His pulse throbbing against her lips. As her pupils dilate to twice their normal size overwhelmed by her predatory instincts to kill her prey.

“Stop it!” Sara rushed out of the back door, with the broom. They used to sweep the floors inside. Smacking Catra’s back, her head, her butt. Striking the little cat girl everywhere in a desperate attempt to dislodge her and free Atila. She had been getting ready for bed, wearing only her under clothes. Of a white tank top and pale brown shorts. Sara was usually a sweet, soft spoken little girl. With long dirty blonde hair that always hung down her back and a somber, almost delicate face that never showed much in the way of strong emotions. Now she was red faced and near tears. Her attack on Catra held a flurry and gile she never possessed during combat training.

“I don’t have it…it wasn’t me!” Atila professed, his rage igniting from the pain along with his primal terror. As he was a prey hybrid, now trapped in a death bite by a predator hybrid. He reached out and grabbed Catra’s tail and yanked as hard as he could.

Catra screamed, as she felt the fine bones in her tail being crushed and pulled apart.

Adora exploded from the bunkroom, still in her cadet uniform. Of a white t-shirt with short red sleeves and her gray pants. She had been getting ready for bed also, since she was barefoot. She rushed towards Atila, with her dagger. A makeshift shiv, of sharp metal. That was a razor sharp piece of shrapnel from the hull of a Blasted out Horde Bot. That she had found in the scrapyard. The hilt was just cloth wrapped around the other more narrow end. She had hidden it under her pillow over a season ago, and had been using it to 'protect' her bunkmates. From the predatory cadets from other squads. The threat of a weapon was usually enough to get them to back down and was a deterrent in the late night sackings of their bunkroom. When other cadets wanted to steal their things, but it wasn't full proof. Things still got stolen, when no one was around.

This was the first time she felt it necessary to threaten her own bunk mate with it.

Atila was heaving for air, Catra wasn't strong but she was fast and wiley. Which made her a formidable adversary.

Catra had let go of his back the instant he had pulled her tail. Now she was sprawled on the ground, tears of intense pain streaming down her cheeks.

"Catra are you alright?" Adora rushed to her side.

The question was infuriating! Because obviously she was not… alright! Catra snapped her eyes up to Adora, her glare scorching in its ferocity. Then she sprang to her feet, leaping up to the top of the fence, leaping down and bounding away on the other side.

"What did you do!" Adora rounded on Atila, blue eyes blazing with fury, the makeshift dagger, gripped tight in her right fist. As she brandished the weapon threateningly inches from the tauran's nose.

“NOTHING!” Atila's brown eyes widened in fear as he roared. Turning and charging away into the bunkroom.

Sara sent Adora a scathing look of betrayal, at her threatening Atila with that weapon. Before racing away after her best friend.

Sara found him, quickly enough hiding away in a shower stall in the communal bathroom.

“Atila…are you alright?” Her soft voice echoed in the empty tile chamber.

“Leave me alone!” He growled back, his voice trembling in both pain and humiliation. He was the strongest of all of the red squad, but Adora…she had scared him, cowed him by the fierce intensity in her eyes…Honestly, for the first time the blonde had embodied that term. If looks could kill…and it had been solely directed at him. He was so frightened he had run like a coward.

But Sara ignored him, his pride was bruised at being intimidated by Adora. With a knowing smile, the soft tempered girl, pushed the stall door open and kneeled before her friend. Atila was sitting tight against a corner, holding a meaty hand against the side of his throat. Blood seeped out from beneath his palm.

“That looks really bad.” Sara stated obviously. Nervously tucking a stray piece of her long dirty blonde hair behind her ear.

Atila merely glowered at her.

“Stay here, I’ll be right back with some bandages.” She nodded and then dashed away.

It didn’t take Adora long to find Catra. She hadn’t gone too far. Retreating to the supply yard, just beyond the barracks. As soon as Adora had seen the large equipment shed doors cracked open

a little. She knew the magicat was hiding inside. The shed was dark and dusty, the smell of mold was heavy in the air. It was cluttered with all manner of large equipment and crates. Perfect for hiding in. Adora never said a word, moving silently through the maze of machines and storage boxes to the very back of the building.

Catra was huddled in the crack between two long cargo containers. Wedged in a small alcove they created. She always felt safe in small spaces.

Adora knelt before the crack, with a sigh.
“Hey…are you alright?” She called, nervously.

“Yes…go away.” Catra shouted back sarcastically, unable to quell her sniffles as she wept as softly as she could.

Adora squinted into the narrow dark alley between the metal containers. Finding the multi hued glow of Catra’s eyes shining back at her.

“Not gonna happen, so either I sit out here or inside. Until you're ok again.” Adora shrugged.

Catra groaned, then huffed. “Get in here then, dummy.”

Adora grinned triumphantly as she crawled inside.

“What happened?” Adora asked, her tone concerned yet also exasperated. It seemed like Catra’s hot head got her into fights almost daily lately. As she sat down beside her. Unconsciously, wrapping a comforting arm around Catra’s shoulder. There was barely no space, so they were pressed up against each other as they sat side by side.

Catra stiffened for a second as she felt Adora’s touch. Adora frowned, she had noticed over the last few season’s how Catra would flinch when being touched.

It hurt that Catra was now fearful of being held. So much has changed since nursery. Living in the barracks was a daily test of survival. They were both conditioned now to never show weakness…to always be vigilant of attack.

That wariness was starting to seep into their alone time too and Adora hated it.

But Catra could also be nursing some bruises? From training or from Shadow Weaver? Who always seemed to be more physical with Catra when she was being reprimanded. Adora got hit, pushed and pulled as well by the Sorceress but not as frequently.

"How's your tail?" Adora asked, pushing down the anxiety about how Catra was curling onto herself as if shielding her body from Adora.

"It's fine…" She hissed, then yelped when her simmering anger unconsciously made her thump her tail against the floor.

"Yep, tail's perfect." Adora chuckled, then crawled back out of her hiding place. "I'll be right back with some bandages." She rushed off, before Catra could complain.

The infirmary in the barracks, was a simple, white washed tile room a few doors down from the mess hall. It was sterile and smelled of disinfectant. With a set of cupboards and sinks against the back wall and several gurney's lined up in front.

Adora knew exactly what drawer's the first aid supplies were stored in, having had to raid the supplies often. For herself or for others in her squad, mostly she did this for Catra.

She found Sara already, gathering tape and gauze from the drawer.

"I need to get stuff from there too, so hurry up." Adora ordered impatiently, folding her arms over her chest.

Sara barely heeded her, sliding her hazel eyes up and then swiftly returning her focus on digging in the drawer. Her heated glare was smoldering with betrayal.

Adora was taken aback by the hard look, Sara was kinda timid and never very threatening. The unspoken violence in that look was startling.

“How could you threaten him with your blade?’ Sara accused, her tone dark with brooding vengeance.

“What else could I do…he’s ten times my size! I had to get his attention? You gotta use whatever you have to assert dominance when in a confrontation like that?” Adora spat back, it was common knowledge for all cadets in combat training. When you were at a disadvantage in a fight.

“He’s your friend!” Sara screamed back, “and you treated him like an enemy?”

“I…did what I needed to do…” Adora defended, suddenly worried about how she had handled things. But unwilling to admit she was wrong. “He hurt Catra.”

“She hurt him, too. Atila’s bleeding real bad!” Sara snapped back, cradling her supplies to her chest as she rushed away. Tears now streaming down her cheeks.

Leaving Adora, standing alone in the infirmary doubting her training for the first time. Ashamed of what she had done. She was quick to push all those emotion’s aside to deal with later or never. She gathered her own supplies and rushed off, worried that Atila’s brute strength may have dislocated Catra’s tail.

It was long after lights out and they were still huddled in the narrow crack between container’s in the equipment shed. Hidden in the security of the complete darkness with the windowless building.

Adora had tenderly wrapped up Catra's tail and pinned it to her hip in a makeshift sling so it could heal. She had her arm wrapped softly around Catra's shoulders holding her gently. As the kitten cuddled up against her. Tucking her face securely into the crook of Adora's neck, breathing in her scent with every hot puff of air as she dozed. A low, rumbling stuttered and stopped as Catra calmed down. Adora had resigned herself to the consequences that awaited them both tomorrow. If they didn't manage to sneak back into the bunkroom before the morning roll call. But if she managed to stay up all night perhaps there was a chance they could avoid punishment.

Adora finally felt it was time to bring up what happened again. Catra may be more forthcoming, now that she feels safe and secure.

"What happened between you and Atila?" Adora inquired softly, whispering against the shell of Catra's ear.

It twitched at the sudden burst of hot air, then with a resigned groan Catra glanced upward briefly. Taking in Adora's concerned expression, her blue eyes searching for answers.

"I was making you a 'Shiny'." Catra confessed reluctantly.

"Awwww…." Adora was touched, Catra hadn't put much effort lately to do anything kind for her so this was very meaningful to her.

"He stole it! I got mad and whatever." Catra grumbled, rolling her eyes. "It's not because I like you!" She declared, as her hand clutched tight to the collar of Adora's training shirt. Unconsciously holding her in place, in case she tried to bolt after her back handed confession.

"Riiiiiight, whatever." Adora chuckled, wrapping her other arm around Catra and holding her securely to her chest. "I *don't* like you either."

Catra's purr instantly ramped up.

Junior Years: Part three

Chapter Notes

> Thank you for the comment Eva Wolf. Glad you came to read this side story to the main Fic. Poor Atila...is right. Between Catra and Adora, his confidence took a major dive. Also thank's to all who left Kudo's. I appreciate them all.

Fourth year…

"Your last holo-simulation was…. disappointing… Adora." Shadow Weaver's voice was thoughtful, modulated. As she found the correct wording to express her displeasure, with her rather trusting and gullible pupil. The sorceress was looming over the small blonde girl, just outside the medic bay. Authoritative intimidation, seeping from every pore of the woman's dark soul.

"I'm sorry, Shadow Weaver. I will do better." Adora's voice stuttered with trepidation, staring up in barely concealed fear. As the woman's stern, glowing white eyes bored into Adora. As the little girl slowly withered under her penetrating glare, subtly being caged against the wall in the corridor. Her blue eyes were glassy with unshed tears. Biting her lower lip to stop it from trembling, refusing to show any weakening during her dressing down by her superior.

She and Catra had both just lost the survival test to Ami and Arron's cheating. Adora's trust and noble nature had been her weakness, which Ami had exploited easily. Adora had failed spectacularly. By being the first cadet in their fire team to be taken out. She had honestly believed that the twins were playing by the rules, at least rules of proper and honorable combat. That she believed excited, here in the Horde. Not understanding the subtle nuances of the word 'Survival'.

So she had come willingly out into the open to combat Ami. Figuring it would be a one on one fight, only to be struck in the back sensor with a rock, by Arron. Who had been lying in wait, hiding in the concealing bramble of to the side of the clearing.

Catra on the other hand had lasted much longer. Evading the twins for a time, with her cunning and natural agility to navigate the trees swiftly. Covering a lot of ground in minutes, keeping ahead of them. While Adora had been stuck trying to navigate through the labyrinth of twisting roots which made her slow and clumsy. Unable to conceal her tracks, which had led the twins straight to her.

Failure was not tolerated…Adora knew the consequences. Private 'tutoring' would be scheduled with Shadow Weaver soon. The mere thought of it, had her chest tight and her breath sharp and shallow as she dealt with her anxiety of what was to come.

Catra was lying prone inside the small alcove a little further up the corridor, on a gurney, in the medic bay. The medic had finished treating her bruises and wrapping her head in a bandage, giving her some foul tasting medicine to ease the pain. The room was spinning sickeningly so she kept her eyes closed, but her ears perked at the sound of their guardian speaking harshly to Adora out in the hall.

"You must not lose your focus, for anything or anyone." Shadow Weaver advised, insinuating in a calculating manner her attachment to Catra. She had done nothing to distract Adora…but it didn't matter. She was getting used to being blamed for Adora's failures. Catra growled, squeezing her eyes tight as terror gripped her chest. Knowing she was too sick and shaky to escape if Shadow Weaver decided to make an example of her in front of Adora again.

The terrible memories of the Black Garnet Chamber still haunted her many years later.

“I will work harder, I promise.” Adora responded earnestly. The brutal memories of disobeying Shadow Weaver by sneaking into the Black Garnet Chamber still haunt her as well. Making her extra careful with her words, more obedient and wary around the volatile woman.

“I trust you will keep your word this time, do not fail again. You are the Squad Leader and you need to be the strongest… unconquerable. Otherwise the soldier’s you command one day will never respect you. ” Shadow Weaver’s tone sounded kind, but it was layered with threat. Fear and intimidation was the cornerstone of their upbringing in the Horde.

Catra’s ears twitched as she picked up on the nearly soundless whimper that Adora held in. As the Sorceress left, the whispering rustle of her long robes as the hem shuffled along the floor fading quickly. Taking the ominous shadow’s with her in her wake. The violent crackle in the air of her dark magic, fading away.

Adora returned to her side moment’s later, a forced smile on her face as she sat down on the stool beside the cot. Catra turned her head slightly, as she felt Adora hold her hand. She looked unshaken by Shadow Weaver’s harsh words. But even though Catra was barely lucid, she could feel the slight tremor in Adora’s finger’s as they threaded with her’s. The sheen of unshed tears glistening in her now dull blue eyes. Shadow’s Weaver’s words had stung, as they always did but Adora was getting better at hiding how she felt. Behind a stone façade of acceptance.

She needed to protect Catra…at all costs. She would do whatever Shadow Weaver wanted, be whatever she wanted…to make her happy.

“Adora…” Catra breathed, her inquiry was tentative in its nature, worried about her best friend. She understood better than most. Whenever you were being chewed out by that horrible woman. The intense fear and anxiety that would course through you, jolting your muscles and making you hyper aware of your

surroundings. It felt like you were being electrified, as that switch in your brain was flipped.

"I'm fine…" Adora responded, squeezing her hand reassuringly.

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A torrential rain storm had confined the cadets in the barracks for the day. It was a rare and very much appreciated day off. As the adults had all been ordered elsewhere to deal with the flooding.

Red Squad had been on their own since daybreak. Left to their own devices, which had consisted of a raid to the mess hall early that morning to gather food, then a quick stop at a supply closet on the way back to their bunkroom. Needing mops and buckets to keep their own living quarter's dry.

The cadets were scattered around the bunkroom, dressed in their training clothes. Entertaining themselves as the rain slammed against the roof. A roaring howl in the backdrop of bright laughter and screams of delight.

Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio were engaged in a game with polished stones. While Sara and Atila were on Lonnie's top bunk reading a book. Max, Levi and Bryson were hunched over something by the back door. Tinkering with some kind of remote they had found in the scrapyard trying in vain to get it working. While Otis and Louis were playing cards up on Louis' bunk across the aisle.

Tossing wadded up ration bar wrapper's at Sara's head just to be annoying.

Atila was glaring right back at them, he had mellowed just a little over the years and wasn't so quick to fight. Which made little bouts of hazing entertaining and no longer life threatening.

A sharp scraping sound, vibrated out from Adora's lower bunk. Followed by embarrassed giggles and raspy laughter.

"I look so dumb…" Adora cackled, watching Catra finish the etching of her face with her index claw, on the side of her bunk. Catra's face had been drawn first and looked cooler, with her wild mane and sharp teeth. Adora's face was goofy looking compared to her's. She figured Catra had done it on purpose.

"Yeah, well you do have a dumb face!" Catra agreed teasingly, she had her tongue sticking out in concentration as she finished scratching the last few details of Adora's hair poof.

'You have a dumb face!" Adora declared, retaliating by pushing Catra down on her mattress. Digging her finger into her armpits, tickling the soft part savagely.

Catra squealed and writhed under her best friend, who now had her at her mercy.

Straddling her narrow waist and pinning her down on the mattress.

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Fifth year…

The cool season has come once more, with freezing rains and endless days of training and classes. The whole squad was feeling the pressure of high expectations and each one was dealing with decompressing in their own ways. Atila and Sara spent their free

time together, exploring the base not showing up until curfew most days.

While Bryson, Levi and Max had started building some kind of fort in the Scrapyard. Otis and Louis were spending more time wandering the outer ramparts, slinging stones over the fortifications into the desolation. That spread out from the foot of the base, as the Fright Zones industrial waste poisoned the land.. Lonnie and Rogelio, spent their free time attempting to improve Kyle's performance in the Holo simulator. Since he was starting to drag their strike team's rankings down. With his poor tactical judgment when in the heat of combat. So they were running extra simulations with him every day in the evenings.

Catra and Adora were always up to something, off on their own, finding adventure and craving excitement. Grabbing a couple ration bars from the mess, instead of eating with the rest of the squad and disappearing until long after dark.

"Catra…" Adora hissed from her bunk. They had been having a sleepover, giggling and telling silly stories to each other. Trying to reclaim the whimsical feelings they had once known with Tama at bedtime. Both missed the little Fox Hybrid like crazy this time of year.

Adora crawled to the edge of her bunk, staring anxiously. Watching as Catra slunk silently across the aisle, intent on tracking down Kyle's sneakers. The blonde doofus had been boasting about being the fastest at getting dressed in the morning. His secret special tactic of always having his sneakers tied ahead of time and slipping on his shoes at the same time. Gave the cat girl a great idea for a prank.

The cat girl paused at the foot of Rogelio's bunk. Ear's twitching, tail high and lashing. The lizard kin had grown tall and lanky over the last few years. His green scaled legs hung low over the sides of the mattress as he snored fitfully. Catra was careful, as she dug

beside the head of the bed. As she snickered, struggling to hold in her mischievous laughter.

"Hurry…" Adora giggled, as Rogelio snorted and rolled in his sleep. Tucking his tail up as he curled into a tighter ball. He never slept with a blanket, it was weird that he wasn't cold. The cadet's rarely ever had the chance to make choices for themselves, always being told what to do, how to do it and when to do it. So if this was a little bit of control that Rogelio needed, even if it caused him discomfort, who were they to comment on it? Catra understood the need to control something, anything just to feel you were a person. Not some mindless robot, given orders and expected to obey…

Catra froze, watching the lizard get comfortable again before resuming their prank. She was quick, finding the boy's sneakers discarded, under a pile of his stinky cadet uniform. Tossed against the back bulkhead. Adora watched her expectantly as she pulled Kyles sneaker's from the pile, finger's working deftly at the laces. Before putting them back in the mass of clothes.

"Up and at'em, CADETS!" Lazlo's booming voice exploded from the doorway of the bunk room. Before the blue scaled mutant strode into the room. His yellow eyes scanning the lumps still curled up under blankets in their bunks. As his head spines trembled with agitation, at their lack of hustle.

Even though the Red Squad had bolted from their bunks a moment later. Dressing swiftly. Catra and Adora stood before Adora's bunk. Pulling on their red and white t-shirts, casting each other conspiratorial looks as they snickered in anticipation.

They had already fallen into the line up before the aisle, fully dressed. When the anticipated squeal of pure terror, exploded through the bunkroom, followed by Rogelio's roar of surprise and the clatter of two bodies hitting the floor.

The whole bunk room erupted into riotous laughter, as Kyle had tripped on his now tied together shoe laces, when he dashed to line up in the aisle. Crashing into Rogelio, from behind, who was standing in front of him. Sending them both to the floor. With Rogelio pinned under the blonde boy, hissing and blushing profusely. While Kyle was sprawled on top of the lizard's back, red faced and overwhelmed by the whole situation.

Lazlo, rolled his yellow eyes. The short spines on his head, vibrating with silent laughter. As he turned and sent both Adora and Catra a pointed look. Knowing who the culprits were, everyone picked on Kyle to a certain degree. But those two pranked the poor fool almost ritually. He never called them out, he couldn't prove it and the little jokes they pulled on Kyle from time to time were harmless. The boy seemed to even enjoy the attention. His friend's were always ribbing him for one thing or another. He was a natural screw up and didn't mind being the center of the joke.

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Adora's face went white for a moment, then hardened into a calm accepting stone mask. As she stared out over the ramparts of the infantry sector. Catra was crouched on the mussel of a turret cannon beside her. Blinking rapidly in confusion, fang's digging into her lower lip as anxiety built in her chest.

The guards were just in the midst of shift change and didn't bother with coaxing the cadets down to the training yards below. Leaving them to observe the Horde's greatest defeat to date.

What remained of the Sixth battalion was limping back to base. It had been a bold, aggressive offensive against the Whispering Woods. The Natural barrier that blocked the Horde's advance towards Bright Moon. Hordak had been boasting for months about

his new weapon of mass destruction. A multi-phase energy system mounted on one of their tanks. The rail-gun type armament was capable of mowing down an entire block of buildings, reducing it to rubble in a matter of seconds. All the cadets had seen the televised tests on the mess hall screen's over the last few months. Hordak was certain that it would blast a hole right through those tree's straight to the castle. That victory was finally in their grasp.

There had been great fanfare throughout the base with the Sixth battalion having charged out to face their greatest obstacle in the war. It was a massive undertaking of man power and military equipment. There were over three hundred infantry soldier's in a convoy of transports, three tank platoons to guard the Rail-gun. There were at least a hundred skiff's sent out to scout ahead of the convoy before engagement.

The personnel left at the base had been filled with a sense of accomplishment. That this time… this time, they could finally achieve victory and end the war. That they could bring to heel the rebel insurgents that plagued them on the front lines of the forest.

To watch the broken, smoking remnants of that once glorious armament of military power, straggle back into the base. It was heartbreaking, at least for the rank and file soldiers of the Horde.

"Hordak's gonna be mad." Catra muttered, eyes wide and fearful.

Adora couldn't even speak, blinking back tears. She felt horrible, her chest ached and her head was pounding with anxiety for the defeated soldier's.

"Let's go up to our hideout…" She finally whispered, needing to be as far away from this horrible failure as possible.

Catra nodded and then leaped down, grabbing Adora's hand and leading her away towards the Forge. They spend the remainder of the day up on their platform. The one place that could make them

feel, completely disassociated from their environment. Allowing them to take a deep breath and relax for a time, perhaps pretend that they didn't live here…

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Time had lost all meaning…since all her senses had been taken from her…there was only darkness…all encompassing silence… trapped with only her turbulent thoughts, spinning round and round inside her head. As she faded in and out of consciousness.

After slashing Adora's face…Shadow Weaver had been livid! Catra had already endured many rather harsh punishments by the Sorceress's hand. Her callous disregard, her cruel words cutting her down, public prosecutions in front of her peers. Her scowls of displeasure…being restrained by her dark magic, being struck and physically held captive by her claw like hands. The veiled threats to her life…but this was the first time the old crone had followed through with it. Punishing her endlessly with dark magic, as the tendril's writhed over her body inflicting unfathomable amounts of pain. Clawed into her mind, forcing her to relive all her shameful behavior. In horrible, mind twisting visions. Draining so completely she now hung lifeless from the back wall of the tiny, dark room.

Her torturer had finally released her and then left her, it seemed. To die in this tiny, closet deep in the forge. Knowing her screams and pleading cries would never be heard over the roar of the furnaces and the banging of the iron works.

Catra had never been so terrified in all her life. Shivering and curled up in the far corner, consumed by fear and regret. As her body ached and muscles felt as if they had been set on fire. Shadow Weaver's parting words still echoing in her mind, leaving

fresh wounds upon her soul that would scab and scar and never truly heal. Adding to the already twisting and deformed reflection of her inner self.

"If you are going to continue to behave like a wild animal with no control over yourself. Then I have no choice but to put you in a cage! "

So here she had been confined, for what seemed like eternity. Alone in the dark, tormented by her thoughts. Her mind spiraling through, fear, loathing and molten rage as she howled and clawed at the metal walls. Screaming in terror and vowing her revenge. When all that spite and wrath had run its course, leaving her exhausted and without hope. She had slumped into the corner, wailing and pleading to be let out. Promising anything, everything she thought Shadow Weaver might want to hear. That she was sorry, that she would do better…that she would never hurt her precious Adora again…

Hunger gnawed painfully at her stomach, her chest ached and her head throbbed. Her voice grew horse then silent, as she became numb to it all. Curled up in the corner, physically and mentally spent.

Feeling forgotten…resigned to her death. Catra came to realize many things…Shadow Weaver would never love her as she did Adora. That she had to finally admit that the woman hated her, wanted her gone…despised her very existence. That she had left her here to die…would spin the same tale she had for Tama, to placate Adora. That she had been taken care of…and dutiful, obedient Adora would swallow it whole, offer the woman a small, grateful smile and then continue on with her life as if Catra had never been a part of it.

She had been unconscious, when Lazlo had been sent to finally retrieve her, from her solitary confinement. The Staff Sergeant never tried to rouse her, she had been gone for days. She was weak from starvation and dehydration. So he merely picked up her now fragile body from the floor and carried her tenderly in his

arms, back to the bunk room. Catra awoke there, in her own bunk above Adora's at dawn. To Adora tenderly petting her head, sniffling softly as she wept.

Adora had been so relieved to get her back. As soon as Catra opened her eyes, Adora enveloped her in a tight embrace. Uncaring how weak she might look to her squad. Clutching onto Catra so tightly, she was nearly crushing the smaller feline girl.

"You came back…" Adora muttered, tucking her face into Catra's neck, soaking her fur with her tears. Catra merely huffed in acknowledgment, too weak to hold her back. Adora would nurse her back to health for several days onward. As she lacked the strength to leave her bunk. Catra would hold the tenderness and validation that she mattered, at least to Adora. In her heart forever.

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Sixth year…

The warm season was behind them and the hot season was beginning.

The cement was hot against her back, soothing every muscle and making her feel like she was melting into a boneless puddle. Catra lay out on the training yard. Arms folded under her head and eyes closed, basking in the heat of the day moon.

It was so nice and peaceful, the dull sounds of engines and marching boots of drill out beyond the chain link fence was like an afternoon lullaby slowly easing her into a fitful nap.

Her peace and tranquility was swiftly obliterated by the annoying poking of a finger along her left cheek, just below her eye.

“What are you doing?” Catra moaned.

“Counting your freckles…I’ve always been curious how many you have.” Adora answered, softly mumbling out her counting.

“Seriously, dummy.” Catra huffed, as the light pressure of her blunt finger’s now reached her cheek.

Catra would never admit how silently she enjoyed Adora's gentle touches. How this innocent little exploration of her face was sweet. It made her feel special…adored even. With a languid sigh, Catra smiled in pleasure as Adora continued her counting on the other side of her face. Her body hovering over her, blocking the light and casting her body into shadow. But Catra was so warm inside from Adora’s affection she never felt chilled.

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Catra stared out over the far off horizon, beyond the grim, macabre structures of the Fright Zone. Her eyes locked on some phantom distant point within the barren desolation that spread out from beyond the base. Lost to her melancholy thoughts. Wandering down dark paths, she had never allowed herself to explore before. But she was older now, so much had happened. Tama was gone…Ami and Arron were gone…yet she remained? She was the smallest, but had never been the weakest and that was an ironic blessing. She had come to rely on her cunning; it had allowed her to survive six long years of the brutal training regime of a Junior Cadet. Their first ever trial was coming up if their squad passed then they would graduate into the Sophomore ranks. Then the training would get even more serious, no more childish games. To increase stamina, or agility, or strength. They

would be training with real weapon's, like power staves, stun batons. They would also have to start preparing for these squad trial's on a yearly basis. Not yet worthy to be televised to the barracks in the mess hall, that honor was only for Senior Cadets. But Catra knew in time, she was going to become someone worthy, someone powerful…she worked too hard not to surpass even Adora eventually.

A slow ambitious smile overtook her contemplative expression.

She had come to learn over the years that Shadow Weaver had no real power, but what Hordak gave her. By allowing her to tap into the magic of the Black Garnet. So now, she wanted to prove herself…in order to be noticed by Hordak because that would actually mean something. Then she could throw her superiority in Shadow Weaver's face. Gloat to Adora that she was better than her for once. The idea of besting Adora had been a childish fantasy, she indulged in as rivals but she had never gotten serious about achieving it. But as she grew older, that fantasy had hardened into a vow. She no longer felt any guilt about winning. It was what kept her going. A goal that kept her focused, as she endured the harsh, unjust reality that was her life.

As the light of day slowly faded. To be replaced by the somber twilight hues of the coming night. Catra reluctantly took her leave of her Sanctuary, high above the Fright Zone. Leaving her platform and climbing down the tower and disappearing into the labyrinth alleys between buildings, heading back to the only home she had ever known.

Returning to the Infantry Sector, to the barracks…to Adora…

Sophomore Years

Chapter Notes

Thank you to all who left Kudo's on the last chapter.

First year…

The air was crisp, as the very beginnings of the cold season had begun to set in over the Fright Zone. The sky was bleak, the day moon hidden behind a thick blanket of gray overcast clouds. This time of year the horizon never changes, frozen in some somber nothingness. As if the Fright Zone had been encased in some featureless limbo. Adora could barely see the vague silhouette of the macabre tower's of the Forge complex. From her perch upon the rounded turret housing of an energy cannon. Positioned upon the battlement wall on the outskirts of the Infantry sector. The smooth metal was cold but not yet covered in frost, the Fright Zone only got below freezing at night. If the desolate region got any snow overnight it usually melted by the afternoon.

The other side of the battlement lay the sprawling wreckage of the scrapyard, with the looming dome of the prison compound in its center. She continued to scan the jagged horizon of patchwork towers, made of spaceship hulls. Her entire world had been this base, her day's marked by training, duty and earning her place above her peers.

Shadow Weaver expected so much from her…she worked endlessly to achieve perfection in everything she was tasked. Failure was not an option…but the supreme amount of effort needed to stay on top was getting too much. The stress and anxiety of being Red Squad Leader had become overwhelming. So she had retreated into solitude for her free time after supper. Sitting up here, contemplating her life for the first time, fantasizing about leaving. Of being free from her current

responsibilities. Her duty to become some great Force Captain that would lead the Horde to victory over the princesses. But honestly she couldn't even imagine what freedom would be like… to make choices for herself, to want things that Shadow Weaver had not already drilled into her to want. She felt guilty even trying. She owed Hordak her life, for finding her and bringing her here as a baby. For Shadow Weaver taking her in and caring for her. This place defined who she was, it gave her purpose…she would feel lost and scared without the security of knowing what to expect each day, what goals to strive towards.

Her bare hands were freezing, so she shoved them into the armpits of her white long sleeve shirt. It had a thick red stripe up each side under her arms and down her sides. Made of a heavier material to help keep her warm. But she had been out there for at least an hour or more, so it was doing little to retain the meager heat she had left. The cold, wet air had seeped through the fabric to chill her skin. Gooseflesh pebbling up her arms, legs and sides making her shiver. She should have put on a jacket before coming outside but she had not been thinking rationally when she had disappeared.

She couldn't bear to be around anyone, as she was feeling far too raw. Stressed beyond her limits, her emotional control was far too thin. It was better if she was alone, she did not want to say something or do something, when she was so volatile.

"Hey, Adora…" Catra's voice was small, worried.

Adora grunted in acknowledgment, turning her head slightly, as she felt Catra's hand clutch her shoulder. Squeezing briefly before retreating, a small, easily dismissed point of physical contact. They used between them, to show solidarity and affection while in the halls of the barracks.

The magicat always had her hands bandaged these days? She had stated it was to protect her hands, because she got into so many fights outside of training now. Needing to be prepared for combat. Adora understood that, she slept with a real dagger under her

pillow now. Their bunk room had been raided in the middle of the night by other squads a few times, since they became sophomore cadets.

They were older now, officially teenagers. The teasing and name calling between squads had turned more violent. She had gotten into her own share of fights in the corridors as well. But the rival squad's never took it too far, the fear of Shadow Weaver's punishments for hurting her protégé always cooling their heads before Adora got more then a few bruises.

Catra was still in her cool season uniform of a quarter sleeve red tunic and gray pants. Her feet bandaged the same as her hands to protect the soft parts of her feet from the rougher terrain outside. Her thin layer of tawny fur over her bare arms was fluffed from the cold. Her long mane tossed in the cold breeze as she settled down beside her.

As sophomore Cadets, 'play time was over. As Lazlo had said, their training regime had gotten really intense, really fast. Learning more lethal combat techniques with real weapon's, military strategy, survival training and hours upon hours of drills. With a crusty old Gar, for a Drill Sergeant. Who was harsh and uncompromising about everything. He didn't care if you were sick, or hurt or cold …you did as you were told and you did it with precision. Or suffer the consequences…which meant endless reps of push ups, or curl ups or chin ups…until you got the marching maneuver's right. Basically, all he did was shout at them all morning.

They were well on their way to becoming fully ranked soldier's.

Their morning calisthenics started early, before the day moon even rose and went on for hours until breakfast. Starting in the training yard out back, with stretches and warmups. The amount of push-ups, curl-ups, pull-ups…and various other stamina and endurance exercises seemed to go on forever. Then Staff Sergeant Lazlo would hand them over to their Drill Sergeant who made them run for several miles out past the barracks and deeper into

the Infantry sector of the base. Moving as a unit, through back alley's between warehouses and along busy avenues full of cargo transports. The variety of outdoor obstacle courses and gym apparatuses were more complicated. It wasn't just climbing ropes, swinging along jungle gyms and balancing and traversing beams, high overhead now. The obstacles were more advanced and it was easy to get hurt if you were not paying attention. With massive climbing walls, towering platforms, ladder's and nets. A water jump, where you had to swing over on a rope, crawl under spiked beams and jog through a 'minefield', where one wrong step would cause an explosion that left you covered in sticky goo. Which took forever to get off under a cold shower. It was strenuous and grueling. Taking a level of tenacity and endurance to get to the other side and only her and Catra seemed capable of at the moment.

There was far more time spent in the Holo-simulator, getting their asses kicked by bots. They were instructed not to just beat their times and complete the training scenarios. They were being trained to conquer whatever might be thrown at them out in the field. With combat drills and weapon instruction all mixed in with their regular classes.

It was a-lot and Adora was starting to feel the strain of command for the first time. Red squad as a whole was ranking alright so far this year. But her strike team was struggling to keep their A rank, thanks to Kyle. She was terrified of disappointing Shadow Weaver. Of not rising to every challenge and meeting those high expectations placed upon her to excel. It was her responsibility to lead her strike team, her duty to keep the squadron all in line and push them to succeed. Adora would be held accountable if her team did not maintain their ranking. They had to be victorious by any means necessary. Which was scary…cause Kyle was their weak link. Always had been, but all the extra time she had spent for the last few season's helping him keep up with everyone else. Was so draining on her both physically and mentally, she didn't think she could keep it up forever.

She could feel her hands trembling in fear, at the prospect of more private, 'tutoring' at the hands of Shadow Weaver. So she quickly tucked them between her legs.

As Catra sat down beside her and scooched closer, bumping her hip against her's.

"You've barely eaten today?" Catra turned, leaning her back casually against the side of the cannon housing. Pulling up one leg and draping an arm over her knee. Her mismatched eyes were soft and filled with concern.

"Just haven't been hungry." Adora explained, shrugging slightly. Refusing to look at her. Keeping her gaze firmly locked on some distant point beyond the Fright Zone. She was having a hard time regulating her emotions, so being self contained within her own little bubble was a must to maintain her control.

"You need to relax, dummy. Before you pop that vein in your overly large forehead of yours.." Catra chuckled, her raspy laughter exploded beside her, bright and Adora felt unburdened. As Catra refused to take anything seriously, she lived for herself. Setting her own standards for excellence and scoffing at Shadow Weaver's cruel assessments and snide opinion's of her. Venting and ridiculing the sorceress to Adora when she felt they were in a safe place for her to be honest with her feelings. She no longer had any respect for their guardian. No longer seemed to try and gain her approval. As infuriated as Adora was at Catra's stubborn, obstinate nature towards anyone in power. Her nonchalance towards their training, always triggered her own anxiety. Adora also coveted Catra's bravery and inner strength of will. To always be herself and not compromise for anyone. Catra's self worth didn't seem to hinge on her achievements…like Adora's did.

Grinding her teeth, Adora turned to confront her, finding her mismatched eyes gleaming with mirth. Irritatingly it seemed, at her expense. As the magicat pressed a finger tip against said

bulging vein near her temple in a lame attempt to flatten it. Since Adora was obviously mad, and was a stressed out mess which was no doubt entertaining Catra.

“Shadow Weaver’s on my ass, Catra. If I don’t improve our strike team’s stats…” Adora shouted and rolled her eyes, burying her resentments towards Catra as she vented. Shadow Weaver had such low expectations of Catra, she felt the magicat had far more freedom because of it. She had the luxury of slacking off and not caring, without dire consequences. While Adora did not, Shadow Weaver held her up to a much higher standard. One she had to live up to…to prove that Catra was not a distraction, or a bad influence…to keep her safe from being punished, or disposed of. While Catra seemed not to care.

Catra slowly pulled back, retracting her finger and arching an eyebrow dubiously.

“Kyle’s really dragging us down right now…” Adora mumbled, bowing her head in shame.

“Adora, sitting up here being all stressed out is pointless. Kyle sucks at everything so you gotta learn to deal with disappointment. I have…what is that witch going to do…honestly… Shadow Weaver needs every warm body she can get to pad our forces? Just so that she can secure our borders and keep Hordak happy. ” Catra shrugged, crossing her arms over her stomach and avoiding Adora’s scathing glare by staring out over the tower’s instead. Her eye’s grew somber and distant. “We’re all just meat for the grinder anyway…” Catra finished by grumbling bitterly under her breath.

Adora obviously didn’t hear that last part, still stuck in her head. Sorting out her thoughts about the whole thing. With a tired groan, Adora scrubbed her hand over her face in an attempt to clear away the stress.

“Yeah, maybe you're right.” Adora sighed reluctantly agreeing, folding her arms over her chest and staring down at the ground

far below. Whatever punishment Shadow Weaver had in store for her, she most likely had already endured before.

Why, let the inevitable upset her. She would just have to accept that it was coming and push through it.

She heard the soft rustle of Catra's toe claws, as the magicat returned to recline against the bulkhead. Then slowly she raised her head, staring at Catra. The magicat had leaned back to lounge against the side of the metal dome that housed the entry hatch to the artillery cannon. One leg was not tucked under her butt the other dangling over the edge. With her eyes closed and breathing deeply as if she had fallen asleep. She looked so peaceful…her cheeks slightly rosy from the cold accenting the smattering of freckles across her cheeks. In the dull, half light of dusk, her naturally sharp features seemed to soften…her wild nature seemed tamed at least of the moment…she was so very beautiful…

Adora blinked and gasped, she had never thought about Catra that way…it was startling. Clearing her throat, Adora turned back to the faceless horizon beyond the tower's. Her heart was beating like a frightened bird in her chest and her face felt incredibly hot… the sudden feelings were weird and hard to understand so she pushed them aside to deal with later.

"What do you think is out there?" She asked, softly. Needing to break the now awkward silence. Yearning for a freedom, she couldn't comprehend.

"I dunno." Catra shrugged, "Whatever it is, we're going to get out there eventually and conquer it. " Her tone was earnest, as if making a promise.

"Yeah, we'll bring order and free Etheria from the chaos of those Princesses' evil magic." Adora nodded, her voice resolute.

"""Soon enough, we will be ruling Etheria together." Catra smirked, as she opened her eyes.

Adora nodded, they had stayed up all night in her bunk last season. Planning to one day take over the Horde and change things, make the lives of other cadet's and soldier's better, the lives of all Etherians better. It had been fun and strategizing their next six years had relieved a-lot of stress for her.

But it had all piled back on in a matter of weeks. Shadow Weaver had instilled in her that she was nothing, she didn't matter. As long as she obeyed her, proved her worth then with her guidance she could become powerful…someone important. That it was thanks to her that Hordak hadn't killed her outright as an infant. So she owes her life to the sorceress…that was a pretty hefty debt to repay.

Adora groaned and flopped backward onto the curved hull of the turret. Arms splayed out at her sides. Catra never said a word, taking a quick survey of the battlements finding them empty. It was safe they couldn't get caught, showing weakness, showing affection…so she would take this chance however brief to be close to Adora. Catra swallowed nervously, then curled up beside the exhausted blonde. Draping an arm over her stomach, loosely. She hadn't the nerve to hold her close, content with just brushing up against her instead, far too scared of rejection to make the first move. So she waited for Adora to take charge.

"It's going to be ok, Adora. Whatever they throw at us next, we can handle it. As long as we're together." She professed, a calming rumble issuing from her throat as she tucked her head into the crook of Adora's neck.

Adora sighed and relaxed instantly, as she pulled her closer holding her tight. Bold and forthright with her affection. With that Catra tightened her grip on Adora's stomach holding her just as tightly.

"Yeah…you're right. " Adora smiled, closing her eyes and basking in Catra's comfort.

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Catra got caught skipping training the next day, hiding in the air vents in their bunk room, instead. She had woken up in the middle of the night sweating, unable to get back to sleep as she grew terribly cold and shivering for the rest of the night. Her body was achy, feeling light headed and vulnerable, she had crawled into the heating ducts to keep warm. Falling into such a deep sleep she hadn't heard the morning roll call. Slumbering through, the ruckus of the squad getting ready and the outdoor exercises in the back training yard. Even the loud droning tone for breakfast in the mess hall hadn't disturbed her.

Adora had woken up to find her missing, frantically trying to find her all day. She had taken off just after breakfast to search all Catra's usual hiding places, skipping the training day. She was so upset and scared of what might have happened to her best friend during the night. Terrible thoughts plagued her like needles to the brain. That Catra had been snatched in the middle of the night, for one reason to another. That this time…this time she would be gone forever. Adora hadn't thought things through, reacting as always to fix the problem instead of contemplating the consequences.

Unfortunately, Grizzlor had found Catra first, his heightened sense of smell had led him to the bunkroom's air vents. Pulling the kitten out by her ankle, she was suffering from a fever and was delirious. Frightened and rudely awoken, Catra had hissed and attacked. Now the Force Captain was sporting a long scratch down his furry cheek and tufts of his darker brown fur was missing on the top of his head. As he escorted the captured cat girl down the corridor to Staff Sergeant Lazo's office.

Adora had run into them en route and tried to cover for her. Having overheard from other cadets that Catra had been found in

the air vents. She was a horrible liar. Giving Grizzlor some wild, far fetched tale about her absence being sanctioned by Staff Sergeant Lazlo. That Catra had been ordered to inspect the ducts for air leaks that morning. Not knowing that it had been Staff Sergeant Lazlo who had sent Grizzlor to find Catra in the first place.

Not able to think fast enough on her feet to realize that it was a stupid excuse! It was an air duct…it had plenty of holes, a.k.a. vents…to let the air out. Catra had groaned in defeat, as Adora blushed in shame suddenly realizing her own stupidity. Knowing she had screwed up.

Grizzlor merely glared down at her, lunging out with a huge fist and clamping it down on her shoulder. Pushing her along with Catra towards Lazlo's office.

He quickly tapped his com badge as they marched down the corridor.

"Cancel your search for Adora, Octavia. I have them both."

"It's ok, Adora." Catra smiled weakly.

"Sorry…" Adora mumbled, reaching for Catra's hand. As they walked down the corridor together. Finding only thin air. Disappointed, she glanced over. Catra was holding herself instead. Arms crossed over her chest and chin down, staring at the metal floor in resignation. Knowing they would both be having extra chores to do for the next week. Adora felt awkward and her chest burned with silent rejection, but she kept her expression impassive. Chin up and staring dead ahead, mentally preparing herself for the dressing down they were both going to receive from their superior in the next few minutes.

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Catra screamed, writhing against her magical restraints. Refusing to beg, it never worked, Shadow Weaver had no mercy. She would never humiliate herself by showing weakness ever again.

Pinned to the wall with dark magic, in that same small utility room, deep in the bowels of the Forge. That she had known as her torture chamber for years now. As vile parasitic magic sank into her very soul, tormenting her with cruel vision's, endless pain and draining her energy.

"Only you can take the pain away…" Shadow Weaver advised pedantically. She was standing in the open doorway to the utility room. The flickering light of the forge behind her a hellish backdrop. One Catra found herself focusing on, as she seethed with rage. Drawing strength from the sight of the inferno to fuel her endurance to withstand the pain of the red lightning bolts, coursing over her body yet again.

"I don't know how…" Catra snarled, bucking and twisting like a desperate, wounded animal under the crimson lightning. Now coursing over her body, electrifying her muscles and searing her skin.

"Control ....Cata…something a wretched, simple minded creature like you severely lacks. " Shadow Weaver explained, with a tired, exasperated moan.

Catra glared defiantly up at her, clamping a fang deep into her lower lip drawing blood. It was a trick she had learned as a child, using the physical pain to block the magic's full effects. It didn't last forever but it was long enough to clear her head and help her survive the assault.

Shadow Weaver noticed, the white eyes in her mask narrowing in scrutiny. Then glowing as the shard of crystal in her forehead sparked. As she drew more magic into her finger tips. The sorceress had figured out her little trick to avoid the full brunt of

her magic and the sneaky little brat was not going to get away with it any longer.

Catra knew that by hurting herself it eased her suffering. Drawing her focus away from the tormenting thoughts plaguing her, giving life to the vision of her squad mates that tortured her. Instead of relief, Catra's eyes flew open with a gasp, her pupils flashing with red lightning as the black garnet's corrupted magic seeped through that fragile barrier of physical pain that usually protected her.

"That is not going to work this time, child." Shadow Weaver sighed, as more lightning sprang from her fingertips and engulfed Catra's writhing body.

The sight of the trembling child's, mismatched eyes transfixed up his vessel. With a look the Nameless One recognized as stark terror was the purest nectar for the demon to consume.

(Delicious…) *A demonic voice whispered in the recesses of Shadow Weaver's soul.*

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Catra had been working hard, for many seasons, to get Hordak's attention. Her grades were decent, her teamwork during holo scenario's was satisfactory, weapon training was excellent. But it was her ranking in hand to hand combat that set her above the rest…even Adora. She was leagues above the rest in her strike team. A natural born fighter! Finally after years of holding herself back, worried she was going to hurt Adora. With her claws or her teeth if she lost control over her instincts. She didn't care anymore, she used all her hybrid senses to prevail instead. Her agility to jump higher, her hearing to evade strikes and her

cunning tail as an insatiable bait…to distract Adora. It was fun and so satisfying to win!!!

Here she was ranked first, upon the sparring mat, she reigned supreme. She knew Adora's weaknesses and she exploited them relentlessly. Using her quick wit to snap scandalous comments at Adora, that left her blushing and flustered. Or taunting her with sharp remarks that slowly chipped away at the blonde's confidence, since she had never won a match against Catra. Manipulating the Adora, through strategic feints…with her tail. Luring Adora around the mat until Catra gained the advantage. Then taking her down hard and fast…every time.

Staff Sergeant Lazlo was impressed, sending reports to Hordak of her excellence. That her skill and tactical mind was surpassing even high ranking Senior cadets. Catra couldn't help the swell of pride that washed over her at Lazlo's praise and the fact that she had finally got to prove her worth to Hordak.

She felt strong and worthwhile for the first time in her life!

While Adora was not used to being beaten at anything…she was surprised at first. But she was also proud of Catra, offering her praise and a gracious smile after every defeat. That Catra ate up like a starving animal. Their sparring matches became more intense as Catra continued to win. Growing more arrogant and pompous, as her natural agility and speed easily out maneuvered Adora. Who counted on her brute strength to succeed. But after being bested a few more times over the course of the season. Even after she had put in extra hours during the following weeks training. She was becoming frustrated, needing to figure out how to win? Shadow Weaver was not pleased with her poor performance, either. She had been chewed out several times already and the sorceress was losing patience. If she didn't improve…there would be hell to pay.

The pressure had been slowly crushing her….as panic set in.

Adora was standing firm in the center of the mat, fists raised and feet spread wide. Her hair was pulling free from her ponytail, wisps from her hair poof, flying wild to frame her face as she panted hard. Her face was flushed and sweat was dripping from her bangs. Wearing a white tank top with red stripes along the sides, gray sweat pants and bare feet. She had grown taller and broader over the course of this year. Her body was packed with hard muscle, from long hours lifting weights in the gym. While the other girls in the squadron had grown into their breasts, she was still rather flat. Her chest was rather small, but still apparent enough to need to wear a breast band.

Catra circled her with a smug smirk, her mismatched eyes darted over the large empty mat around them. Taking in their surroundings, Adora's defensive stance…calculating and strategizing her next set of moves. The young magicat was still quite thin. But she had filled out, sporting curves and perky breasts, that she had not possessed a few season's prior. Her core was toned, the defined muscles in her thighs flexing with every movement. Wearing a short, bright red tank top that left her stomach bare and black shorts. Her hands and feet were wrapped in cloth. Her long mane was fluffed up as her hackles were raised. Long bangs cascading over her eyes, obscuring her sight slightly. Catra ignored her hair, used to compensating for it getting in her eyes. Squinting and tossing her head to move the hair out of her face. Her pupils were blown wide, from the intensity of their fight. Her wild, untamed nature is on full display. As she circled Adora, as if prowling after her prey.

"Hey, Adora…you're looking kinda tired there." Catra taunted with a raspy giggle, keeping her hands up, finger's splayed wide, as she adjusted her position.

"I'm just getting started." Adora countered, between pants. Hands balled into tight fists, cocked up to her chest ready to throw more punches.

The overhead spotlights were piercing, shining down from the metal beams in the gym's over arching roof. A static hum, buzzed

through the massive gymnasium. Both of the remaining two strike team’s from Red Squad crowded around the edge of the mat. All hushed and holding their breath, the match was close, one more point to which either of the girls would win. Lazlo was hovering near the out of bounds marker on the mat, officiating the match.

While Shadow Weaver was lurking behind the small crowd of cadets, observing their combat. With a silent, disapproving scowl behind her placid red mask. So far Adora's performance was lacking, she was holding back, refusing to go all out to win against Catra. While Catra never had such honorable intentions, she had so far been ruthless. Seeking not only to beat Adora, but to humiliate her as well.

Catra cackled, “Awww, so cute! You thought you had me cornered there, didn’t ya. Adora.” She teased pompously.

Adora narrowed her eyes, glancing nervously towards Shadow Weaver. She was frustrated and angry and scared of looking foolish in front of her superior. She needed this win! She had thought she had pinned Catra to the mat, in a submission hold. But the cat had wiggled and twisted her supple body in an absolutely absurd angle and then sprung free in seconds. Scratching up Adora’s arm’s with her toe claws in the process. It was infuriating how Catra didn’t play by the rules. Now Adora was bleeding down both arms, dripping on the mat.

Desperate and not thinking, Adora screamed and rushed Catra, arms out preparing to grapple her, again. Catra merely laughed, side stepping and then twisting behind her. Sending a roundhouse kick to Adora’s back hard enough to make her stumble. Nearly losing her footing, as she was forced to compensate her feet for balance. Stumbling and lurching forward like a complete novice.

It was soooo infuriating, the magicat was just toying with her. Wanting to make her look foolish in front of Shadow Weaver! Catra didn’t fight fair…she was too fast, too erratic, her combat moves all her own. Coming up with them on the fly. Not using

any of the grapples, kicks or punches they were taught…so she couldn't counter or even forecast what Catra was going to do!

Dammit she is making a mockery of her!

"Com'on Adora…you can do better than that?" Catra admonished, shaking her head in disgust.

Adora spun on her heel, sending several rapid fire jabs towards Catra's gut. The feline jumped straight up in the air, avoiding the strikes easily. Curling her knees up into a forward flip, then landing on Adora's shoulder blades. Kicking Adora flat on her stomach to the mat as she leaped upward into a forward flip. Landing behind the sprawled blonde with a victorious shout.

"Match point, Catra." Lazlo swung his arm down, calling the match.

Adora groaned, keeping her face hidden in the mat to hide the couple stray tears that had escaped.

"Ha, ha." Catra cackled triumphantly, raising her hands up in the air as Red Squad cheered her victory.

Adora sighed heavily and slowly rose to her feet.

"I'll beat you next time." She professed, quietly. Eye's downcast, refusing to look up at Catra or Shadow Weaver.

"Sure you will." Catra crowed from over her shoulder, hands on her hips.

Completely unfazed by Adora's defeated slouch, her downcast eyes. As she rubbed a finger under her nose and sniffled. Turning on her heel and shuffling out of the gym to the locker room.

"Catra!" Shadow Weaver bellowed, as the hiss of the automatic doors to the gym opening hushed the small victory cheers of the kids surrounding Catra.

Catra sucked in a scared breath, turning slowly and fighting not to cower. Her guardian shouting her name, evoked such a sudden and primal fear inside of her.

"Come with me.." Shadow Weaver curled her boney finger, beckoning Catra to walk by her side.

"Yes….Shadow Weaver." Catra obeyed, a low irritated growl rumbling in her throat. As she trudged after the sorceress, expecting she was going to get chewed out about something. Perhaps because she didn't fight right? Having developed her own style over the last few years. She still used the core combat techniques they had been taught…she had just tweaked it a little so she could use her hybrid abilities to her advantage? Lazlo had watched her develop her fighting style for years, he never said what she was doing wasn't allowed? He had complimented her many times on her creativity and cunning while in the ring.

So why was Shadow Weaver mad? Maybe it was because she had been wiping the floor with her Golden Girl? The longer she followed after the floating shadows in the Sorceress wake, the more furious she got.

By the time she had led her down the corridor to a small window that overlooked the massive tower's of the forge. Catra's whole body was strung tight like a spring ready to snap. Preparing to evade at a moment's notice if the Sorceress became violent.

"Lord Hordak has been watching your performance closely, Catra. He is quite impressed." Shadow Weaver began, arms crossed behind her back stoically.

Catra held her breath, keeping her distance. This was the first time she had ever garnered any kind of praise from the witch. She was unsettled, not knowing how to act. So she remained silent, waiting.

"He believes with the right guidance, you could become a fine candidate for Force Captain one day." Shadow Weaver, folded her

hands over her stomach. Staring out the window, keeping her emotions calm and contained.

Catra couldn't read her, she was shell shocked to hear such complimentary words coming out of her mouth. For the last thirteen years, all she got was ridicule and toxic opinion's about how she wouldn't amount to anything!

"Thanks…I guess…" Catra was nervous.

Shadow Weaver sighed and then chuckled bitterly. "Just as I expected."

"What…?" Catra felt like she was on thin ice, after the last flippant comment.

Shadow Weaver, reached into her robes and pulled out a copper mask.

"For your hair, to keep it out of your face."

Catra slowly reached for it, her heart hammering in her chest. Wary of taking it, believing it may be some kind of ploy to get her in close. So the Sorceress could strike her or bind her somehow.

She had zero trust that Shadow Weaver had any good intentions. All that woman had ever done was manipulate and hurt her.

"Take it!" Shadow Weaver shouted in exasperation.

Catra snatched the mask out of her claw-like grip. Holding it to her chest with trembling hands as if it was going to explode.

"It is a battle mask, worn by a Magicat warrior. You have the tools now to become someone powerful. Use them…show me what you are capable of." Shadow Weaver turned on her heel and floated away down the corridor.

Catra's smile was so wide she was beaming, her eyes bright and hopeful for the first time in her life! She raced away back to the

bunk room to show Adora, before they headed for lunch. She was so thrilled with her new mask, she quickly etched it into her drawing on Adora's bunk post. All while gushing to Adora about the praise she finally earned from Shadow Weaver! Adora had smiled and congratulated her. But Catra failed to notice the defeat shimmering in her blue eyes, so filled with joy and acceptance for the first time.

Adora never showed up for class after lunch, which made Catra confused. Or to supper in the mess hall which left Catra concerned.

When she showed off her mask in the bunk room before heading to lunch together. Adora wasn't acting upset or angry with her? Adora had seemed happy for her. A bit withdrawn, sure. But Adora had spent years, defeating her in everything. It was time for her to shine for once and she refused to feel guilty about it! When lights out came and Adora still had not shown up. Catra was starting to panic.

Catra was stretched out on her top bunk in her dull gray underclothes, bandages still wrapped tight around her hands and feet. With a huff, she turned and grabbed her mask from its hanging place on the metal pillar beside her bed. Hopping down from her bunk and landing softly on the floor, sneaking silently out of the bunkroom.

She scoured the halls of the barracks, until she heard the sharp cries and grunts of combat coming from the gym. She approached cautiously, the double door's hissing open obediently. The raw brutality that confronted her within stole her breath and left her trembling with rage and guilt.

Adora stood upon the mat, soaked with sweat. Her hair was pulled free from her ponytail, hanging in wild knotted mats down her back. Blood was caked along her right temple. Ragged, desperate pants rattled from her throat, as she was trying to take

in enough air and cringing as it hurt to breathe. Her lips were dry and cracked, cheeks flushed and glistening with sweat. Blood covered her face, dripping out of her nose that looked slightly bent at the bridge, as if it had been broken earlier. Both of her eyes were badly bruised, swollen to narrow slits. Her sunken stare was hollow. Devoid of any emotion, but utter exhaustion. Her cheeks look puffy, her face swollen from getting punched too many times. Her training clothes were ripped and torn. Her shirt hanging loose over a bare shoulder barely staying on. Catra could see the gray strap of her breast band. The knees of her sweat pants were rubbed thin, dried blood crusted on what remained of the fabric. She shuffled around a Senior Cadet more than twice her size, her legs trembling and barely able to keep standing. Several other Senior Cadet's were standing around the mat, some already bloodied and bowed, while others were still fresh waiting their turn to fight her…but at this point it was more like to beat on her.

They had been waiting years! To be given the chance to take revenge upon Adora without the threat of Shadow Weaver's retaliating and they had been making the most of it.

Behind them all was Shadow Weaver, standing within the concealing darkness in the far corner of the cavernous room. Her glowing white eyes, observing the outcome of each fight from behind her mask. As she forced Adora to 'train' for countless hours against opponents more than twice her size.

Catra was frozen for all of a second, as white hot wrath exploded inside of her chest. A howl of rage tore from her chest, echoing off the cavernous room. Like a vengeful roar. A war cry rising out of her from some feral, primal core.

Her most precious person was fighting for her life! Devotion, so pure, so powerful, spurned her into action. She sprinted across the gym on all fours, claws fully extended and digging into the hard polished surface, leaving jagged scars every time she surged forward. Ears pinned flat, hackles raised high and tail lashing like a whip behind her. Mismatched eyes flashing with a fiery malice,

to exact a very painful and bloody retribution upon all who had harmed her Adora!

The older cadet's turned in fright, as she leaped over their heads. Landing in front of Adora. Hissing and crouching low, claws gleaming in the bright overhead lights. A stance of protection, threat pulsing from every coiled muscle in her compact body.

"Stay away from her!" Catra bellowed, the sharp corners of her battle mask shining with a deadly aura. Flashing her teeth and growling menacingly.

Adora's opponent was taken off guard and took a step back. Glancing nervously at the other cadet's seeking some kind of guidance or perhaps back up? As to what to do next. Did he fight Catra or run? The Hybrid had such a fierce, rather deadly glare in her eyes.

His confusion soon lifted as he locked eyes with Shadow Weaver.

"It's not your fight….Cat…" Adora slurred weakly behind her. Her indignation at her interference was rather moot. She could barely lift her arms.

Catra merely growled, raising a protective arm up to shield Adora from the older teen now adjusting his stance. Regarding Catra with a determined grimace, his eyes hardened with resolution, Horde Cadet's were not weak and they were definitely not cowards. Backing down, retreat…was never an option. Shadow Weaver would never allow it.

"Do not interfere, child." Shadow Weaver's irritated voice slithered over the whispers of the crowd.

"You set this up…didn't you!" Catra accused her, as the Sorceress hovered into view behind the crowd of cadets.

"Adora was not giving her all, when fighting you. She was giving into weakness, refusing to hurt you, refusing to do what was necessary to win. She lacks that killer instinct you seem to have in

spades. So she needs the proper motivation to succeed. I do not tolerate failure." Shadow Weaver, explained as if stating simple facts.

It was appalling and Catra instantly felt sick at how cut throat she had been with Adora just to be noticed by Hordak. Bile rose in the back of her throat. With a sick sounding gurgle. Overwhelmed by revulsion at her selfish behavior, she swallowed hard. This was all her fault…Adora was being punished because she had refused to hurt her to win…while Catra had had no issues with doing whatever was needed to win, to be seen..to be valued…she had never felt so horrible…or more monstrous…never again…her value was not worth Adora's life!

The blonde's consequences for failing were too great. It hurt, her heart felt like she was ripping it out but she made her choice. She would keep Adora safe, by being second, by always being by her side. In this way she could protect her.

"So be it." Shadow Weaver sighed, snapping her fingers as she floated out of the gym. Washing her hands of the outcome, no longer caring about how this forced gladiatorial match would end.

The cadet's looked at one another, not understanding what kind of command that was. Having to decide for themselves if they were going to fight the furious beast Catra had become or retreat.

The cadet's Adora had already defeated rose up from the floor and took their leave. They had done their duty and had the wounds to prove it. The ones still fresh on the side lines moved in along with Adora's opponent.

Adora hadn't said a word in minutes, her legs were trembling so hard she couldn't stand anymore. Falling face first onto the mat unconscious, without uttering a single sound. With Shadow Weaver gone, she had permission to succumb to her injuries.

Catra chuckled menacingly low in her throat, as the Senior Cadets converged upon her enmasse.

"Bring it!" She snarled, eye's darting and counting her adversaries. Calculating her movements as she raised her claws and sprang into action. Throwing hooks with claws fully extending and snap kicks with her toe claws flashing. Spraying the blood of her enemies as she slashed deep into their soft bodies. Ripping and snarling like a wild beast. Leaping and biting their necks, possessed by the hunt and the killer instincts of her ancestors. Within minutes, she had conquered her prey. Leaving the mat in shreds from her claws and the bloodied bodies of the fallen, lying like leaves scattered over the surface. The few that remained standing, their uniforms shredded and hanging like rags, blood oozing from wounds scattered over their torso's and necks. Eyes now round and terrified, as they all rushed out of the gym to seek out the medic on duty.

Catra stood victorious amid the carnage, her battle mask baptized in the blood of her prey. A huge, feral grin spread wide over her face. Fangs dripping, claws red and pieces of fabric fluttering upon the razor sharp tips.

Her most precious person lay behind her, safe and sound.

Never again…she promised…Shadow Weaver would pay for what she did…eventually.

Sophomore Years: Part Two

Chapter Notes

Thank you to all who have left Kudo's.

Second year...

"Kyle…this could be the dumbest thing you've ever done." Lonnie groused, having grown into her full figure over the last couple seasons. Her once tight curls she had as a child had grown out over the years and were now braided into long dreads, pulled back into ponytail.

A low roar followed Lonnie's assessment of the crazy situation the trio had found themselves in. Rogelio was now towering over both of them, with broad shoulders and thick limbs. His green scales had darkened and hardened as he matured. His light green frill he had as a child now spiking upward from the crown of his scaly head.

"Or…or it's pure genius." Kyle offered,with nervous enthusiasm. The young man now had shaggy blonde hair that hung low near his thin shoulders and his oily face held a smattering of pimples. They stood on a metal branch within the holo simulation of the Whispering Woods. With Lonnie and Rogelio standing on higher branches close to his. They all had their sensor's in place upon their bodies and VR Goggles over their eyes. Dressed in their red and white t-shirts and gray pants of their warm season uniforms.

Each one holding their power staves like spear's, as a huge bot with a malicious looking hologram of the Queen of Bright Moon overlaid on top, clanked into view amid the fake structures of holographic trees.

With a determined cry, the trio threw their staves in a pinpoint attack to hit the sensor embedded on top of the Bot's central

core.

The staves merely rebounded off the bot's outer hull, causing no damage and clattering to the floor uselessly.

“No, Kyle, that was just dumb.” Catra goaded, as she sprang from her perch several branches away, just north of their location. Dressed in her warm season uniform, of a sleeveless maroon tunic and black leggings. The pressure sensor vest draped over her modest chest and VR goggles pressed tight to her face behind her battle mask. As Adora broke cover below, her power staff hummed in her hands as it charged up. Wearing all the same gear as everyone else on the strike team. In a short sleeve white and red t-shirt and black pants and gray combat boots.

“Dang it…” Kyle grumbled, shoulder’s slouching in defeat. As a howl of energy fire exploded dead ahead. He snapped his head up in surprise, just in time to watch the bot fire upon them.

Rogelio leaped aside, taking cover. Lonnie was about to do the same, when Kyle was blasted dead center in his chest sensor with a laser bolt. Screaming in pain and surprise as he was propelled off their branch.

“Kyle!” Lonnie cried in fear, scrambling down the tree to check on him.

As the blonde boy lay sprawled on the floor, a red x now glowing on his chest sensor. His teammates hovering above him, staring down at him with shock and humiliated grimaces.

Adora and Catra moved in sink with one another, attacking the bot. With Adora moving in a zig, zag pattern through the tree’s, while Catra leaped and bounded through the branches. Adora struck low with her staff, taking out the bot’s legs. While Catra leaped atop its central camera eye, claws extended. As she ripped out its ocular sensor. The two had dispatched the bot in seconds, leaving it crumpled and smoking amid the holo program.

“Very well done!” Lazlo congratulated them, as the simulation faded away. His attention is more on Adora than Catra. As if their joint attack had been her plan instead of Catra’s.

Adora hung her arm over Catra’s shoulder with a proud grin.

“We are an unbeatable team!” She cried, giving Catra a firm shake. By hooking her arm around her neck and jerking left and right.

Catra smiled weakly at her, as she was sharply jostled. She had stopped competing with Adora. So now their combat rankings were exactly the same. She was her equal in everything, yet received no recognition for her efforts. Conceding the limelight to Adora. It was frustrating and kinda soul crushing, not to live up to her own potential. To willingly, remain in Adora’s shadow…to always be seen as second best…the sidekick…

She had finally gained Shadow Weaver’s approval and her mask last year. It was all she had ever wanted. For the first time in her life, her ambition and skill had been acknowledged, endorsed even. She had hoped that she could become someone great in the Horde, a Force Captain…a leader. Then it was snatched away, as all good things were. When that vile crone enforced her power over Adora….over her. Forcing Adora to fight for hours on end against numerous cadets twice her age and twice her size! That she knew had grudges to settle with the blonde. Standing back in the shadows and watching the bloodthirsty combat. Teaching both of her Wards a very important lesson. To Adora, she learned that failure…equaled death…It had steeled her resolve never to let her guard down, never give up and always strive for excellence no matter the cost.

To Catra, she had learned that there was a cost to her winning. She had been forced to choose, her ambition or her loyalty to Adora. It had been a cruel lesson, but she had learned it well. She knew her place…but she was still struggling to accept it.

Catra exhaled softly, rolling Adora's arm off her shoulder and walking away. Heading for the locker room to take off her sensors and stow her goggles. It hurt to throw away her dream's, but she was making peace with it.

Adora was worth it…she meant everything to Catra.

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The hot season…

The locker room was more rowdy than usual. The clanking of doors and echoing laughter of their fellow squad mates. Was a discordant song that filled Adora with satisfaction. They had just thoroughly destroyed Green Squad in the trial of tactical combat in the Holo-simulator. It seemed that this year perhaps they might have a chance of winning the yearly trials!

Catra was leaning against her locker, arms crossed and one leg braced against the metal door. A smug, self-satisfied smile in place of her usual disgruntled scowl. They had all done well!

Adora closed her door, having deposited her gear.

"We are unbeatable this year!" Kyle exclaimed, as he strode proudly through the archway and into the locker room, with both of his arms over his head. The trio was the last of the squad to leave the holo-chamber and enter the locker room.

"It was the first test in the competition, Kyle. Relax, we got a whole lot more to go before we can start celebrating that hard!" Lonnie commented with a bright grin, punching Kyle in the arm as she moved towards her locker.

Rogelio growled, putting Kyle in a head lock and grinding his fist into the top of the sandy blonde's head. Kyle wailed in discomfort and struggled desperately to get out of the Lizard's hold.

Adora laughed with amusement at their antics, casting Catra a small companionable glance. Their hand holding and nightly cuddles had waned over the years, replaced by the same happy go lucky rough housing as the rest of their squad. Finding the Magicat was smiling too, enjoying their squad's good spirits.

Their dynamic had changed so much in the last year. Catra had been pulling away, at least that's what Adora thought. She didn't confide in her like she used to, every time Adora managed to get her alone and inquire at how she was doing. She would deflect her concern, depending on her mood it would be some snarky remark to back off or a jaded self deprecating joke. Catra had become more verbally combative with their squad mates, especially when they screwed up in training. The tension she created was intolerable at times and Adora couldn't always protect her from getting her ass kicked, especially when she pushed back against Atila who had a temper to match the magicats. It seemed she had stopped taking training seriously, just putting in time. Doing the absolute minimum to keep her second teir ranking.

The competitive rivalry they had been ensnared in since childhood was replaced by an uncaring nonchalant attitude about everything. Catra had become more disrespectful towards Shadow Weaver, not shying away from throwing flippant remarks at the sorceress when being dressed down publicly. Uncaring how much more angry that would make Shadow Weaver. Submitting to her with a fake apology and casting her eyes aside. Showing just enough obedience to appease the Sorcerer.

Her sour attitude had become intolerable. Begrudgingly obeying orders, given by their superiors. Catra's tongue had become sharper,more caustic. Lashing out in rather mean, vindictive way, uncaring about the consequences to herself or the pain she caused others.

It was rare to see her show any passion or drive like she had in the holo- simulation. She had been a force to be reckoned with, in there. Their strategy for a two prong attack with their two fire teams had been a brilliant success. It was like the Catra of a year ago had shown up and Adora really missed that version of her.

"You were on fire in there!" Adora elbowed Catra, with a smirk.

"Yeah, well. I did my part, don't make a big deal about it." Catra responded dismissively, with a proud chuckle. Knocking her shoulder against Adora's, as she struggled to conceal her own grin.

"Always the team player, huh." Levi groused, turning from the sink in the corner. Holding a gauze pad over her left eyebrow, that was already stained with blood.

"I am…when my team member's don't suck!" Catra shouted back, hands on her hips and fury burning in her sharp feline eyes.

Levi growled and stalked forward. "You were nothing but a glory hog in there! So busy showing off, you never even thought about the safety of the rest of us!"

"Hey…now…calm down." Adora was between them in seconds, her arms up to hold either one back. If one was to lunge.

Max moved from behind the lockers at the shouting, standing next to Levi in solidarity. "You just need to be more observant of your team member's is all." He shrugged.

"I took the high ground…and I got us the win! None of you losers could do it!" Catra snarled, crossing her arms over her chest.

"I was in position below you asshole! I got a metal pole in the head when you leaped off that 'tree branch' in the simulation. Just to gain a few extra seconds of speed, so you could pull ahead of everyone else and attack first?" Levi grumbled.

"If I didn't engage as quickly as I did, the Green squad would have out flanked us before the rest of you slow asses managed to get into position!" Catra was now pushing her chest against Adora's bracing hand. Tail high and lashing aggressively, all her muscles clenched tight ready to throw down.

Max had gotten in between as well and was holding Levi back. Who had thrown her used gauze pad to the floor, uncaring about the blood now trickling down the side of her face. Eyes blazing with rage, fists up and ready to exact some retribution.

When the creeping shadows that once crawled over the back wall of the locker room, exploded over the room. Which always gave Shadow Weaver's menacing presence away.

"Enough!" The sorceress bellowed.

Catra instantly froze, cringed and spun into a defensive stance with her back against the bank of lockers. The rest of the squad merely stood at attention, fearful but unthreatened by her outburst.

"I can hear you're shrill squabbling all the way down the hall." Shadow Weaver ranted, folding her hands over her stomach and steepling her finger's sternly. Glaring coldly down at Catra, a silent accusation that the tension within the squad was her fault.

Catra gnashing her teeth, holding her fury in check. Used to being blamed for everything that went wrong. Refusing to accept it was fault, silently fuming at Shadow Weaver's obvious bias against her. There was no point attempting to explain her side of things, Shadow Weaver didn't care.

"We're sorry, Shadow Weaver." Adora jumped to apologize and placate her guardian. Anxious to fix the situation before things got worse. Chivalrously placing herself in front of Catra, protecting her. Catra couldn't help but cower slightly behind Adora. Instantly the magicat's confidence was crushed by this knee jerk reaction of sublimation towards the Sorceress. She hated how easily her

presence still brought on such overwhelming terror, she was stronger now older…why can't she banish this weakness…

Shadow Weaver harrumphed, eye's narrowing in distaste at Catra. Who stood silently, eyes cast down and to the side refusing to look at the sorceress. Feigning a contrite and submissive attitude in the Sorcerer's presence.

"You all did well, you should be celebrating not fighting." Shadow Weaver praised, with a mentor's warmth. "Tomorrow's trial is a hand to hand combat tournament of all the second year sophomore cadets. Adora, you need to choose your teammates very carefully." she continued, "I suggest you think long and hard about who you want fighting alongside you." She finished, staring pointedly at Catra. "You will need more than just skill this time to win. You need to be able to trust in their 'capabilities', to fight to their full 'potential' and not be a 'liability' while in combat. She was still staring at Catra. Who was now grinding her teeth and stubbornly blinking away tears as she continued to stare at the floor. She knew exactly what Shadow Weaver was insuateing. She had sent a good deal of the Senior Cadets into the infirmary with very serious injuries because of her teeth and claws last year. It was very apparent now that if Catra lost control of her instincts while in combat she could easily kill another cadet.

"I will." Adora agreed, sliding a brief glance at Catra. Understanding the silent prod from Shadow Weaver to exclude the magicat. Adora had been unconscious and never witnessed the blood bath Catra had invoked on her behalf. Shadow Weaver secretly had the severely hurt Senior Cadets cared for in a private medic bay. Writing up fake reports of training accidents to cover her tracks, so Hordak wouldn't punish her for misuse of resources. She had then wiped the senior cadets' memory over the incident. But the primal fear they felt towards Catra still remained and they all kept a wide distance from her. Which Catra was fine with, having been sworn to secrecy herself on threat of death by the Sorceress. She never spoke of the fight and never would, the vile woman's commitment to protect Adora was clear.

So Adora was oblivious of the silent reprimand passing between the Sorceress towards her Best Friend. She believed it was because Catra had stopped putting in as much effort into training this past year. She had been doing just enough to keep her rank, never trying to stand out or be noticed. Shadow Weaver had been calling her out all year about not taking her training seriously. About being lazy and unfocused. How she was squandering her potential and would amount to nothing in the future. That she had become a dispaointment.

Catra stood with her ear's dropping, her expression bland, devoid of emotion. Eyes cold and impassive as she was verbally dressed down yet again in front of everyone else. Swallowing her humiliation as always, sealing away her hurt and sadness behind a wall of silent rage.

"Very Well, then. You have decision's to make, I am sure you will make the right ones." Shadow Weaver nodded and took her leave.

As soon as the sorceress had disappeared down the corridor, Adora turned to Catra. Rolling her eyes with disregard to Shadow Weaver's words and grinning assuringly at Catra.

"I am still picking you for my team, I don't care what Shadow Weaver says."

"Don't do me any favors!" Catra kicked her heel into the locker angrily, denting it before stalking out of the locker room. The one thing she excelled at! The one thing she enjoyed…that miserable, bitter woman had taken away.

She hated her!

Hated this place!

Hate, hate, hate!!!!

Catra stormed away from the barracks, retreating up high, to the only place she felt safe and untouchable. To the platform high above the Fright Zone, that overlooked the behemoth of clustered towers that was the Forge. The pulsing engines mounted to the side of the building, glowing in the half light of dusk. The intensity of their illumination, showing how much power was being flooded into the base's power systems.

Catra narrowed her eyes, the only sound in the dead silence was the click, click, click of her toe claws tapping against the metal floor. She sat on the very edge of the open protruding deck, the rusted out forward railing having fallen away a few season's back. Leaving the platform to the open air, making hanging out up here just a little more risky. Which only made Catra gravitate to it all the more often, to perch and brood for long hours. She had her arms crossed tight around her middle, knees pressed up tight to her chest and tail curled around her ankles. The tip flicked sharply with irritation, as her thoughts spun around and around in bitter, angry circles.

The heat of the day was ebbing away, as the day moon set, the smaller moons ascended into the sky. The light was fading slowly into an inky darkness, as Catra sighed heavily and raised her chin up to watch the world turn black above her head. The blank void of nothingness that covered the sky at night was lonely and bleak, it suited her mood well.

She fingered the sharp edges of her mask, as bitterness and hatred towards her lot in life dragged her even further down into despair.

She had no idea what she had done to make Shadow Weaver despise her so much, how she never seemed to be enough for her. The sorceress had always been so cruel towards her, always seeking to make her life worse.

"Catra…" Adora's tentative call, only infuriated her.

Catra snapped her head back, glaring furiously towards the breathless blonde. Who had just finished her climb, with her grappling hook hanging from the top railing. Crawling under the back rail that abutted against the bulkhead of the peak of the tower.

"Why can't you just let me disappear when I want to!" Catra snarled, turning back to glower down at the open air beyond the platform.

Adora froze for only a moment, at Catra's subtly self destructive choice of words.

"Because…I…" Adora was struggling to find the right words, she was nervous about saying the wrong thing and making things worse between them. She hated when Catra disappeared, it always made her anxiety skyrocket that she was never going to see the magicat again. She had already lost many friends over the years. So she always went after Catra…an obsessive need to find her and make sure she was ok. She could lose her too!

Adora cleared her throat and tentatively sat down beside her on the edge. Dangling her booted feet over the side, staring down at the endless drop to the street below. Oddly, enjoying the sudden swooping feeling of fear, it caused inside her gut.

They sat in silence for a long time as night set in. The lights in the tower's surrounding them begin to glow softly. Creating some strange, artificial starlight.

"Talk to me…" Adora offered softly. "I know something's been bothering you for season's Catra and I want to help."

"You can't help me Adora, you never could." Catra spat, turning away from Adora. She could never, would never talk about what Shadow Weaver did to her.

Part of her just couldn't face it, a larger part was that she couldn't trust that she wouldn't break down and start bawling if she ever verbally admitted what had been happening to her. That show of

weakness would be far too humiliating and she wouldn’t survive it.

Adora swallowed, feeling tear’s prick the corner of her eyes. Catra had been blocking her efforts to reach out for a long time. Slowly cutting herself off from her, from everyone. Becoming more aloof and unapproachable for years.

Adora didn’t know how to fix their relationship, the rift between them had been growing deeper and wider for years. She was unwilling to ever give up on her best friend, but sometimes trying to figure out how to fix them seemed so hopeless.

"Brat." Adora smiled teasingly.

"Dummy." Catra responded in kind, raising her eyebrows tauntingly.

“Ass-hat.” Adora spat with a smirk.

“Bitch-hole” Catra spat back, the brooding darkness in her eyes lightening just a little.

Adora giggled. Catra bumped their shoulders, her turbulent emotion’s soothed by this old game of tagging slurs with random objects that their bunk room had been engaging in for season’s now. It was stupid but fun…

It eased the tension and soon they were laughing and cringing at the combinations as they went through the alphabet. They didn’t open up to each other anymore about their problems. They were just too personal and honesty would not repair the damage, so they both learned to avoid those conversations and just be happy alone with each other any way they could.

In time the game had run its course and silenced reigned again.

“I need you tomorrow, Catra.” Adora pleaded.

“I can’t Adora, you know Shadow Weaver has it out for me.” Catra advised. “She is not going to allow me to participate. “

Adora groaned in frustration. “I’ll handle her, I promise.”

Catra turned, gaze hopeful that Adora meant what she said. She loved hand to hand combat and she was really good at it and had not been able to give it her all in season’s since the ‘incident’. Searching her now hardened blue eyes, that were staring at her with such earnest determination.

“Alright, I’ll fight, but this is not because I like you.” Catra teased, flipping Adora’s ponytail over her shoulder. The Sorceress loved taking away all joy from Catra’s life. But she would trust Adora one last time, that she would have her back and stand up to that manipulative control freak for once.

Things turned out pretty much as Catra expected. As soon as Shadow Weaver found out about who was registered to fight for Red Squad she had taken Adora aside just before competition began. Now Catra was sitting on the end of the wooden bench with the rest of her teammates. On the sidelines of the mats in the gym, waiting for the inevitable. Her confidence from yesterday that Adora would finally step up and put that old hag in her place, crumbling like a dried out ration bar.

“Do you think this is wise?” Catra’s ear twitches, as she overheard Shadow Weaver’s disappointment with Adora. That she concealed in a mentorly way. They were both standing several yards away, near the companion bench of a rival squad deeper along the mats.

“She will be fine, I have complete faith in her.” Adora advised, casting Catra a reassuring smile over her shoulder.

“I believe your faith will be tested, my dear. We both know how volatile she is. Are you prepared to shoulder the consequences, if

she were to lose control and kill someone in the ring today?" Shadow Weaver's tone was low and full of threat.

Adora instantly cringed, grinding her teeth as her resolve began to weaken. She shifted her bare feet, ducking another, less certain glance back at Catra. As she was forced to really look objectively at her best friend. Reviewing her recent lack of commitment to her training and combative nature towards her squadmates. Could she really trust that Catra would control herself? Not getting swept away in the fury of the moment and hurting her opponent… the possibility that she might kill someone to Adora was rather hard to believe but not impossible…in the end Shadow Weaver had put enough doubt in her to cause her to bow her head.

Catra nodded, knowing at that moment she had lost Adora's support. Adora turned with an apology on her lips and remorse in her eyes. Catra wouldn't let her speak, so she stood up and bolted out of the gym.

If Shadow Weaver was gloating about how easily Adora was to control. Catra never stayed around to see it. She retreated away into the bowels of the base and never returned for many days.

When Catra finally showed back up at the barracks just at lights out. Adora was a broken mess, at least in private, in the quiet of the night. When the rest of the Squad was asleep. Standing meekly on the ladder, seeking forgiveness and apologizing softly to Catra.

"I'm sorry…I know you're mad…but what could I do?" She pleaded, picking at the corner of Catra's mattress nervously.

Catra refused to even look at her. Curled under the blanket, facing the forward wall. Ignoring her weak entreaty for forgiveness. Silently, fuming.

'You should have believed in me! You should have stood up for me…you coward!' She screamed in her mind. In the end, Adora endured her silent treatment for another week and slowly, slowly

their relationship returned to normal. With a few more cracks in the foundation.

Sophmore Years: Part Three

Chapter Notes

> Ok, here we go. Enjoy another update. That you to all who left Kudo's.

Third year...

The Sophomore and Senior cadets were ordered to assemble in the amphitheater. As junior's they were only called to the theater to witness badge ceremonies, when hero's of war were awarded medals and new Force Captain's were commissioned. It was like a mini vacation from training, so Catra was all on board. Red Squad matched in line down the grand hall of the barracks, a wider, more elaborate corridor that led to the amphitheater. The walls were lined with simple portraits of all the honored soldiers and Force Captains that had lost their lives on the battlefield during the First Princess Alliance. Plaques that held their names, rank and deeds were hung beneath the frames. Along with a simple quote, "Glory to the Horde." The hall inspired many cadets to reach for greatness, including Adora.

Staff Sergeant Lazlo led his squad to the massive double doors at the end. Filing into the huge, dimly lit amphitheater, in which several other squads were already seated upon the metal bleacher's that ringed a huge stage in the middle. Dominated by a viewing screen, mounted high above to a metal girder.

The room was buzzing with a strange, dreadful energy…not at all like the exciting anticipation the junior cadet's had when they were assembled in the Great hall.

Catra sat quietly next to Adora, hands tucked between her legs and ears pinned back. Sensing the tension mounting around her, her tail wrapped tightly around her waist. Catra hated assembly,

the low, abrasive hum of too many voices and the movement of far too many bodies all around her, sent all her instincts into overdrive. The sharp edges of her battle mask flashed, everytime Catra swiveled her head to keep track of the smothering crowds of cadet's currently vying for seats around them. The bronzed metal reflecting the overhead lamps, piercing Adora's eyes every time the blonde tried to look over at the tense magicat. Checking on how Catra was handling the congestion of the crowds. Forcing Adora to squint and rub her eyes with a finger. Refusing to accept that she herself was nervous and kinda scared right now.

Catra glanced over to Adora, she was practically pressed up against her thanks to the crowds and Catra could feel her tremble. Her tail twitched, as she resisted the urge to wind it around Adora's wrist and comfort her. Holding her tail firmly in both hands, keeping it under control. Catra was observant enough of Adora's subtle tells, that she knew Adora was scared and unwilling to show it. But she would not embarrass her further with public affection. Clearing her throat she stared dead ahead, refusing to even acknowledge Adora's presence beside her. But it took only a second, as Adora shifted her weight on the bench. For Catra to snap her eyes back towards the blonde.

It was the very beginning of the hot season and within a few weeks their yearly trial would begin.This would be their third time and so far they had lost every year. Adora's uniform was looking well worn, the rounded neck on her t-shirt was frayed and she had several holes in the right armpit. Her black pants were loose and she had to wear a belt now to keep them on. Catra didn't know if it was because she wasn't eating as much lately or the fact she had grown taller.

Catra's uniform on the other hand was in even worse shape, her red sleeveless tunic was worn thin and faded from too many washes. Her dark lavender pants had rips in the knees.

The soft hum of the crowds grew eerily silent as the lights dimmed into complete darkness. As the grim interior of Hordak's throne room came alive on the view screen, with a sudden flash

of static. Rows upon rows of Horde trooper's were assembled at the bottom of the raised dais, with Force Captain Grizzlor standing at attention at the front.

Hordak sat brooding on his throne, in his full plate armor. His ghoulish countenance hidden in the shadow's of his raised cowl that protected the back of his neck. Pale face and fearsome red eyes glowing with malice. His pointed chin braced in the clawed hand of his gauntlet, was a truly terrifying sight to behold.

The aura of raw power and wrath that wrapped around Hordak like a cloak sent chills down every cadet's spine.

Adora had never seen their respected leader look so angry? She held her breath and swallowed…her hand searching blindly for Catra's. After a few weak pats on the bench looking for it and finding it absent, she finally turned. Finding the cat girl, trembling and holding herself instead. Both of her arms were hooked around her stomach holding firm, as if she had a belly ache.

Adora blinked rapidly, drying the well of tears, shielding her hurt feelings at not being given comfort by pressing her hands between her legs instead. They rarely held hands anymore… When had Catra stopped reaching out to her for comfort? When did it all change? When did reaching out to one another become a weakness? Something shameful to do in public?

"Let this all be a lesson to all of you. There is nothing I do not know, nothing that I do not see…" Hordak's voice boomed like a thunder clap through the dark theater.

As Adora snapped her gaze back up, her blue eyes growing wide in horror as a prisoner was led up to the throne in chains.

The man was in nothing but rags, but his stained and shredded shirt still held the red Horde insignia of a soldier on his back. He could barely walk, half starved and emancipated from the

inhumane conditions inside the military prison. The guard's had to hold him up by his elbows.

As soon as they let go, the broken soldier fell forward onto his knees. Weeping and prostrating himself before Hordak, begging for forgiveness. As another set of guards dragged in another soldier, he was also unable to walk on his own. His booted feet dragged behind him as they hauled him up to the throne. This man was beaten badly. His whole face was swollen, blood covered his entire face, dripping off his chin and staining the front of his shirt.

"”Well, now you two are in a sorry state?" Hordak smirked, arms crossed behind his back as he stalked back and forth in front of the prisoner's at the foot of his thrones staircase.

"But I can be merciful…the truth will set you free…I do not tolerate failures lightly. But deceit or betrayal. Will be met with a swift and painful death." He promised, glowering down pointedly at each soldier in turn.

The starved man wept more loudly, while the beaten man whimpered, still hanging limp and delirious from the guard's arms.

"Both of your Strike Teams are missing? Yet you two survived… Why?"
"The Whispering Woods is haunted…by the headless Princess…I swear it! " The weeping soldier choked out.

Hordak said nothing, merely thinning his already very thin lips in distaste. Hearing his soldier's spout such nonsense, only infuriated him more.

"We entered the woods and traveled deeper for many days, with the reconnaissance convoy..all we had were a handful of skiffs and survival packs. We set up the observation post on a ridge, Northwest of the Wailing River. We could see the tip of Sky Dancer Mountain…to the east…so we knew we were close to Bright Moon.

Everything was fine for a couple days..but the scout's sent to find a pass through the valleys wide enough for our bot's… began to report strange voices calling to them. Then I started losing men..it was only a couple at first..but every time I sent out scouts they never returned…the woods seemed to swallow them up…we found no trace of any of them. I called a retreat and I led what I had left out of the woods…but the tree's…they moved I swear it! The forest lured the other skiff's off course and only my skiff…with my lieutenant was allowed to leave…I…think…the Whispering Woods wanted me to deliver a message…that it will not let the Horde enter…" The broken down Force Captain whispered with dread.

Hordak nodded, rubbing his chin. "Did you deploy my tracking beacon's along your route?"

The soldier wilted instantly, cringing and cowering lower.

"I'm sorry my lord…my men were panicking and I just wanted to get them home safe.." He whimpered….

"Useless!" Hordak bellowed, back handing the man across the face so hard. That his head snapped back with a sickening crack. Then he slumped forward onto the floor of his throne room unmoving.

Hordak paced back to his staircase, shaking his head.

"Dispose of the prisoner's…we are done here." he ordered, mounting the steps. The demonstration of Hordak's power and the consequences of failure was over.

With that the feed cut off and the cadet's were ordered to their bunkrooms to contemplate how best they could aid the Horde. The Senior Cadet's were not as shell shocked as the Sophomore's, having already watched many of Hordak's displays of power. But every cadet had left with an innate fear of being useless to Hordak.

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The Fright Zone before dawn was rather surreal. The lesser moon's were scattered over the barren sky, peeking behind the looming macabre of tower's, of the immense fortress. The streets were empty of the typical daily congestion of traffic. An eerie, peaceful silence reigned, as Red Squad moved in drill formation, jogging side by side in two lines. Along the side of a wide thoroughfare. All of the cadet's were in identical combat uniforms, mostly. The human cades had a heavy duty, dull gray flack jacket. While the hybrids had similar ballistic vests, slightly modified to suit their various physical traits. Each one had a fully loaded pack, secured to their backs. That barely moved as they jogged.

Adora stood out at the head of the line, having finally earned her Red Squad Leader jacket after last year's trails. She had a black leather belt clipped over her waist with a horde insignia buckle. She was in charge of maintaining her squads pace. Her movements were brisk, pumping her fists and legs in a well practiced gait. Her blonde ponytail snapping behind her, blue eyes steeled with determination. Expecting the rest of her squad to keep up.

Catra was right behind her, as her second in command. Her battle mask firmly upon her brow, with a similar leather belt with a slightly different colored insignia. Of a Horde buckle clipped to her waist. Her bare feet slapping the pavement in the same crescendo as Adora's boots.

The squad passed under the giant, open gates of the metal ramparts that circled the Infantry sector and onto the open tarmac of the militia yards. The hulking rounded shadow's of the supply warehouses lined the horizon as they moved across the flat pavement. Their boot's an echoing cadence, thundering over the still morning.

Their Drill Sergeant was keeping pace beside them. A tall, muscular Gar that had taken over their daily combat drills, including their yearly survival training. He was at least seven feet tall. His shoulders were overly broad, arm and legs were thick. Dressed in similar gear as the human cadets, except he had a vest like the hybrids. His skin was the color of an old bruise, a very pale green that was not common among most of the Gar's in the Fright Zone. Who's skin tone tended to range from gray to purple. He kept his ebony black hair cropped short and buzzed to his scalp around his thin pointed ears.

None of the cadets of Red Squad knew his name, he had refused to give it. Instructing them only to refer to him as Drill Sergeant.

So when he screamed out his order's for them to increase their pace once on the tarmac. The whole squad screamed back.

"Yes, Drill Sergeant!"

Then Adora began to chant, her voice bellowing into the half light of the rising day moon. As the sky on the far off horizon began to glow, as if fired from the forge.

"Up in the mornin,"

before the break of day." .

Catra was quick to continue the chant, her ear's flicking as her voice exploded from her chest.

"Drill Sergeant callin,

I don't like it!,

No damn way!"

The rest of the squad took up the running cadence immediately after.

“I’m outta my rack..

Red Squad is up and roll’in.”

Jump in my boots and sling my pack,

Fuck, my feet are swollen.”

They were headed out of the base for their annual survival training out in the barren desolation beyond. It was the only time they were allowed to chant the more crass cadences full of slurs. The whole squadron took up the chant, their voices booming over the open pavement.

“Hungry as hell, I eat to soon,

Ration bars taste like crap.

I’m puke’n my guts out before noon.

Cause I’m runn’in on the tarmac.”

“Lean and mean,

Trained to be a fighting machine.

Fit and ready.

We will hit you hard and heavy. “

“‘One mile, no sweat!

Two miles, you bet!”

“Three miles, better yet!

Four miles, I’ll never break a sweat! “

“Fuck, yeah!

Red Squad!”

“Fuck yeah!

Red Squad!”

Hoo-ahh!” They screamed into the open air, as they left the fortress far behind.

Senior years...

Chapter Notes

Thank you to all who left kudos!

First Year…

It was just before dawn, the hot season was winding down. Bringing the cold rain's that finally dampened the sour smells of chemicals, rot and machinery oil. That always hung in the air of the Fright Zone like a putrid fog. The tin walls of the barracks creaked, as the rain pelted the overarching roof. A well memorized lullaby for the cadets sleeping on their bunks inside.

The bunk room was bearable to sleep in now, as the night's had become cool again. The stench of sweat isn't as noticeable, when the cadets were not so overheated they were soaking their sheets.

Catra was on guard at the end of Adora's bed, curled up in her gray tank top and tight black shorts. She had stopped taking off her mask at night. Wearing it now even to sleep. Unable to feel safe anymore, always in survival mode.

Becoming Senior Cadets had not made them untouchable by other squads, it seemed to just embolden them. Fights in the corridor, in the mess hall, even out on the primary drill yards, Was a daily occurrence.

All the senior cadets were out to prove themselves to Hordak. Red squad was no exception, for being overzealous to show their prowess in combat. But Adora would not allow them to start fights, only finish them. To avoid punishments, for instigating discord among the ranks.

Currently with the change in season, the squads were out scavenging for item's to help make their bunkrooms more tolerable for the cold season. Which meant nightly raids were becoming almost epidemic.

Adora had been thrashing most of the night, so wound up with anxiety she was fighting in her dreams. Over the last few years, Adora would fight in her sleep, almost every night. Catra blamed Shadow Weaver..f.or Adora being incapable of ever getting a good night's rest. Being forced to fight for one's life….even if you barely remembered it. It left invisible scar's…on you that never truly healed. Catra understood those kinds of wounds more than most.

In the quiet moments, up on their sanctuary. Their platform, which overlooked the Forge. They may vaguely speak about 'the private tutoring' they received from Shadow Weaver of the years. But their shallow, rather vague confession's about what they went through. Were always rather awkward and quickly discredited as no big deal. Adora would fall back on, defending their Guardian. That she was tough on them because she cared...she was doing what she had to. To make them strong and capable soldier's. Catra would scoff and roll her eyes in disdain, venting that Shadow Weaver was just a bitter old crone. Who enjoyed making them suffer. Neither of them are willing to be truly vulnerable with the other.

So as always, Adora's restlessness would draw Catra down from her bunk, to resume her quiet vigil over the blonde at the foot of her bunk. As she had done for many years now. Adora was suffering and Catra was struggling to find ways to soothe her anxious mind at night. She was unwilling to cuddle her anymore. Being that close, yearning for more and knowing nothing was ever going to come of it. Has become painful in the last few years. It was better not to get her hopes up anymore and set firm boundaries to protect her heart from breaking.

Catra's chest aches in the quiet hours, watching the blonde's writhe in her sleep. Adora's small cries and low moans tickled her

ears. Setting her heart jumping. The weak flailing of her arms and jerking legs was painful to bear. Catra had come to terms with the suffering she endured here. But to see Adora struggle in her sleep…it hurt. Wistful fantasies ran through her thoughts, of running away with her. Taking their chances in the Waste or the Whispering Woods. Just so they could be free…to do what exactly she didn't know. She just wanted to be away from this horrible place, from Shadow Weaver. Who did nothing but hurt her and their friendship.

It was so confusing and painful trying to sort out her feelings, how could she care so deeply for someone she also resented so wholeheartedly. Her relationship with Adora had become so very complicated.

Adora's brows furrowed as she whimpered, the soft sound of distress instantly snapping Catra back to being fully alert. Her ears perked up as her tail thrashed behind her. Feigning sleep, she kept her eyes closed and head down on her crossed arms in front of her. Listening to the scuffing strides of boots out in the hall. At least two cadet's were lurking just out front of their bunk room doors. She couldn't help the low growl, rumbling deep in her chest.

Rogelio's long, thick tail thumped against the floor, his own heightened senses picking up on the two interlopers. The Lizard-kin's bunk was just across the aisle from Adora's. Making them the first line of defense during night time raids. Catra cracked an eye open, grateful she was going to get back up from the lizard hybrid when she jumped the two cadets in a few moments.

Rogelio had grown considerably large in the last few years. Now he had the bulk and height of Atila, which made him a formidable alley to have at your back when in a fight. His frill had shortened into dark green spikes along his head. Making him look even more fearsome.

Then Adora rolled over, arm snaking under her pillow to grip her pillow dagger. She never opened her eyes, but the slight

adjustment of her legs and the flexing of her biceps alerted Catra that she was awake and preparing to fight. Adora had become a very light sleeper over the years, certain sounds instantly waking her up.

Catra turned her head, just enough to grin eagerly at the blonde. Who was now staring at the door just ahead of her bunk, her blue eyes hardened to sharp steel.

Whatever those two thieves had come to steal, would not be worth the wounds and broken bones they were about to incur. As they were not going to even make it through the front door.

The fight was over in minutes, Rogelio, Adora and Catra sprang out of the slowly opening door and jumped the two rival cadets from Green Squad that had been hovering out in the hall. They dispatched the startled cadets swiftly. Outnumbered, they flanked them and pushed them back down the hall. As they fell into a defensive posture. Pipes raised and shuffling back to back. Rogelio tripped one with his tail in mid retreat. While Catra pounced on the one, Rogelio tripped. As he fell backwards, slamming him against the floor. As she crouched upon his chest, snarling in his face. Adora lunged at the other. He defended, sending a right hook into Adora's jaw before she pressed him into the wall with her arm. Dagger poised at his throat, the tip digging into the soft flesh near his jugular, just enough to draw blood.

It was over, the wild fear in both of their eyes spoke of their surrender. So Adora pulled back allowing her combatant to sprint away down the dimly lit hall. Catra followed suit, stepping off her prey. So he could scramble to his feet and dash away after his comrade.

Adora heaved for breath, hands on her knees. Then rubbed some blood away from the corner of her mouth with the back of her

wrist. The would be raider's had been beaten back, bloody and limping. Leaving Adora, Rogelio and Catra grinning smugly in victory out in the hall beyond their bunkroom. Having fought them off in nothing but their underclothes.

Rogelio clapped the blonde hard on the back, sending her stumbling forward. Before disappearing back inside their shared quarters. Leaving the two alone in the dimly lit corridor.

"Thanks." Adora stood up, sending Catra a warm grateful smile.

"For what…having ears?" Catra retorted smartly.

"You were curled up at the foot of my bed again…standing watch." Adora pushed her shoulder. Completely oblivious to her sleep fighting, which had been the real reason Catra had been in her bed in the first place.

"It's not because I like you!" Catra pushed her shoulder back. "Your bunk is just more comfortable than mine."

"Suuuure it is." Adora drawled, walking back through the automatic doors to their bunk room. With a very embarrassed and furious magicat prowling in behind her.

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It was the middle of the night, several weeks later. The sound of clashing steel rang through the empty corridor. The steady bang, followed by sharp grunts only heightened Catra's anxiety. The cat girl was pressed up tight against a bulkhead, at a wide intersection several corridor's away. Peeking around the corner briefly. Her ear's twitching at the tell tale beeping of an egg shaped security bot patrolling through the intersection of hallways several meter's behind her, now.

She was dressed in nothing but her underclothes of a gray tank top and black shorts. Her pupils were blown wide, chestnut mane flying wild around her shoulders. Battle mask firmly in place.

Having navigated cautiously through the late night halls of the barracks for the last forty-five minutes. Tracking Adora scent. Her dark claws fully extended and breathing rapidly from the sudden frantic sprint across the large open intersection earlier. Having to seek cover down a side service hall. Hiding behind a thick waste water pipe, that took up the majority of the alcove she was in. As the patrol bot passed by. Not wanting to get caught out of bed. All of her senses were on alert, from evading the bots patrolling the halls after lights out. She had swiftly moved within the shadow's along the main corridor, putting some distance between her and the bot. Slipping between two bulkheads to maintain her cover and wait, in case another one was patrolling ahead of her. Her ear's twitching as she listened for the bots' innate beeping.

She was on a mission, one she could not fail. Adora had snuck out of her bunk hours ago and had not returned. The day moon would be rising soon, if she wasn't back before roll call. The whole squad would be up on latrine duty for the whole barracks next week. With her sensitive nose, she really could not handle that putrid punishment anymore. So she was going to make sure she got that stubborn blonde back in time. She knew exactly where to find her, this wasn't the first time she had snuck out of bed in the middle of the night to work out her stress. It would not be the last time either.

She had found her countless times over the years, beating the ever loving shit out of the sandbag in their locker room. But tonight, Adora had sought out a more physically punishing endeavor to release her pent up energy.

Catra tracked the workaholic blonde to their barracks weight room. Finding her laid out on the bench press, pumping iron. Wearing nothing but her sweat soaked underclothes, her bare feet were flat on the floor. Toes curling every time she lifted the

weighted pole upward. Grunting under the strain, her back arching slightly off the bench.

Catra leaned casually against the door frame, unwilling to intrude right away. Admiring Adora's finely toned form and bulging biceps, as she lifted the iron bar laid heavy with weights on either side. She had grown several more inches in height in the last few seasons. Large breasts finally filled out her chest. The off white tank top had ridden up on her stomach, revealing her tightly packed abs. Her blonde hair was flying wild and wet out of her loosened ponytail, her poof was no more, her long bangs now cascading down her cheeks. Her flushed face, dripping with sweat…muttering her reps as she lifted the bar up and down like the fucking robot she was. When it comes to physical endurance. Able to just focus solely on the task at hand and push through the pain.

She had no doubt been at it for a while, before Catra woke up at the foot of her bed to realize she was gone. They had had a sleepover tonight, having snuck into the bunkroom from their platform just before lights out. They had needed some time alone, together. To decompress from surviving the first few months of Senior cadet training. Jumping from Junior to Sophomore had been difficult to adjust to. Being a Senior Cadet was like a holo-simulator set on hard-mode with all the safeties turned off! Drill was insane! They had to run miles every morning, grab a quick breakfast. Then navigate the obstacle courses in the main drill yard. Of high walls, ropes and other types of athletic platforms. That left their arms burning and their legs near collapse. Lunch… then it was off to class for a few hours. Supper, the evening spent as a Strike team, running holo-simulation's in full gear, till their eyes bled from those stupid holo-goggles they had to wear! Most days they would all fall asleep before their head hit the pathetically thin mattress at night. Their training was just so grueling and relentless, the days and nights bleeding to an endless torture session of physical and mental exertion.

They all felt unprepared for what lay ahead of them this year. Everyone on the squad had different ways of dealing with the

stress. No one coped well, some were more self destructive than others. But none were more brutal than Adora and her extra training regime. That Adora put herself through just to stay on top.

The blonde never gave up, pushing herself to her limits and beyond for years. Catra didn't know if she should be proud or terrified of the girl's tenacity to prevail no matter the cost. Honestly, she found Adora's constant lack of self preservation rather annoying. She never thought anything through, just plowed ahead trusting that her body wouldn't give out no matter what she put it through.

"You are way too tired to be doing this. You are going to hurt yourself, dummy." Catra finally called, sauntering over to the bench and leaning over her with a taunting smirk. Pressing a fingertip between her eyes.

"I am not tired…" Adora huffed obstinately, grunted and pushed the bar full of weights up with trembling limbs. Catra was quick to withdraw her hand, crossing her arms over her chest instead. Scowling indignantly, at Adora's rebuff.

"I'm weak…and I can't be weak." Adora grunted and huffed, pulling the bar down and then struggling to lift it back up. Her arms were so fatigued that they had locked, refusing to move, her wrist began to bend against her will. Her eyes flew wide in surprise as the weight of the bar rolled forward to crush her throat.

"Fuck!" Catra cried in alarm, snapping her hands under the bar and squatting to help lift it off of Adora.

"Fuck…fuck…fuck…" Adora groaned in panic, as Catra struggled to push the bar off her throat. The weight was far too much for the magicat to lift let alone push!

"You…idiot…I can't move the damn thing!" Catra cried furiously, adjusting her stance and her grip. Attempting to maneuver one

side of the bar to the floor. As soon as Adora had enough leverage she pushed upward on one end. The weights on the other side clanged to the floor harshly.

Adora gasped for breath and shimmied off the side of the bench to the floor. Letting go of the bar as she rolled away, the bar fell back onto the bench with a resounding clang. Then the weight on top, carried the bar down the length of the bench until it fell to the floor with another even more abrasive explosion of sound. That had Catra's ears pinned to the back of her head to protect her hearing. Even though it was too late and her ears were ringing painfully anyway.

"What were you thinking! Lifting that kind of weight without a spotter!" Catra was outraged, racing around the bench and kneeling before a humbled Adora.

Who had her head bent between her raised knee's, wheezing painfully.

"I guess… I wasn't…" She finally answered weakly, slowly raising her head to offer Catra a slow, apologetic smile.

"Ugh…" Catra releases a long suffered groan, rubbing a hand down her face. Adora always pushed her personal training too far, one of these days. Catra was terrified she was going to find her dead…"Let's go get you in the shower and back to bed before Lazlo show's up." She finished with a huff.

"I'm…sor…" Adora began, sluggishly climbing to her feet.

Catra spun back around and poked Adora in the forehead with a claw.
"Shut up!" She growled, hiding her worry and fear, behind an air of irritation and a mocking smirk. Then promptly took Adora's hand and led her away from the equipment towards the locker room.

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Catra pressed herself more tightly into the tiny nook. Her lithe body wedged at the back with her knees drawn up tight to her chest. Between the two stacks of metal crates at the end of the equipment shed. Biting her lower lip between a fang, as she held her errant tale close to her chest, as it fought in her grasp. Attempting to twitch and sway, to release the pent up anxiety and excitement inside of her.

With the unset of the warm season and finally being able to go back outside. The cadet's pent up energy and the release of weeks and weeks of boredom. Have evolved into a new game….or perhaps a new torment for some.

Hybrid hunting…

The younger, less experienced hybrids and some of the less violently inclined had ended up in the infirmary beaten and broken by the gangs of Senior cadets. Currently hunting them for sport. A few of those would be hunters were also currently keeping the hybrid's company in neighboring medical cots. With grievous wounds of their own, thanks to the more violent and feral hybrids they had chosen to hunt. Adora found the whole game repugnant and started up a resistance cell of cadets from all the squads. Who now patrolled the barracks after hours, seeking to protect the hybrids and stop the hunt.

Catra was not in a good position and she knew it. The gang of hunter's had been tracking her for the better part of the evening. A few had caught her once outside the Indigo Squad's bunkroom on her way back from the mess hall after supper. She had been on the defensive ever since, being chased out of the barracks compound and into the open drill yards beyond. Getting cornered

from time to time by other hunters and having to fight tooth and claw to escape.

The day moon had long since set, the overcast sky blocking whatever meager light the lesser moon's could cast. The only light coming from the overhead lamp posts along the main thoroughfares of the Infantry Sector. Leaving the rest of the sector in complete darkness. Which suited Catra well…

She was currently hiding out in this tool shed, attempting to gather her wits. She needed to get up high to escape and not be seen…which was hard to do in the Infantry Sector since there were no tower's or massive warehouses to climb. Just squat tin buildings that sprawled over a cement tarmac full of tool sheds and training equipment.

She had already sustained a few injuries from the initial beating and the skirmishes she had gotten into along the way here. She had a limp now from a twisted ankle, bruises along her flanks, back and arms from deflecting metal pipes. Desperate to avoid a strike to the head, that would have left her unconscious. She would rather endure more pain to her extremities than ever allow those bastards to win! Her right arm was slashed pretty good near her shoulder, with a matching gash along her left thigh. She was regretting the maroon tunic she had chosen as her training uniform this year; it did nothing to protect her arms. Which were now rather sore and throbbing from evading and combatting her hunters most of the night.

But she wasn't going to let them trap her! As soon as she heard the crunching of their boots just outside the metal sliding doors to the shed. She leaped upward, using her claws she easily slunk to the top of the wall of crates and slipped into cover behind a tarp. That was partially draped over the topmost crates.

From here she could keep an eye on them and attack…she had the high ground now and the advantage. Having lured them into the shed by not covering her tracks outside, she had a nice confined area that was out of sight of any other cadets that might

be hunting her. To dispatch these would be hunter's with absolute ruthlessness.

She had been picking them off a few at a time, whittling down their numbers as the night stretched on. She didn't know how many were left, but refused to give into the exhaustion currently gnawing at her. Pushing herself past the weakness of her body, through sheer spite and raw hatred. She would be the victor of this hunt or die trying!

Creeping to the edge of the crates, her ears flicking forward. Fully dilated pupils tracking the two cadet's clumsily making their way past a couple grounded Runner's near the entrance. The lead cadet had a flashlight, casting the narrow beam ahead. Barely illuminating their cluttered surroundings.

"Here, kitty, kitty!" The taller, more burly young man called tauntingly. He had no weapons out, but that didn't mean something deadly wasn't hidden somewhere on his body. His shorter cohort chuckled, gripping the steel pipe in his hands closer to his chest.

The Senior Cadets had to lock up the Hordes, real weapons that they used in training. So after hours hunter's had to find makeshift weapons to take with them. Mostly pipes they used as quarter staffs and makeshift daggers all scavenged from the scrapyard.

Catra was not going to give into the bait, she slunk lower upon the crates keeping herself hidden. Tucking her tail between her legs as she crouched on all fours, waiting for them to get just a little closer before she pounced.

As soon as she could see the white's of their eyes, she sprang off the crates. Her powerful hind legs rocketed her forward as the wooden boxes came crashing down behind her.

The two young men screamed in terror, as she fell upon them. Claws and fangs fully unsheathed to exact maximum damage. The

burly boy shifted into a defensive position, meaty fists raised as his companion swung the pipe for Catra's head.

The feline ducked, slashing the taller boy across the knees. He screamed and crumpled to the floor, the sharp clatter of a blade ringing in the dark shed. He had pulled a knife, if she hadn't been so quick to maim him. She might have had a blade to contend with, perhaps already sheathed in her thigh or side. She had no worries about being killed, the hunter's always aimed to incapacitate their prey. So they could present their catch to the other's and gain bragging rights for bring down the most deadly of hybrids.

But Catra didn't have such compulsion, she was in survival mode. Her instincts to kill, screaming inside of her.

The rapid fire battle tactics exploding through her mind, had her blood pumping and chest heaving. Adrenaline and exhilaration, electrified her muscles as

Catra rounded upon the shorter young man. Who was no longer startled at her sudden assault and was now prepared to fight. With an arrogant sneer he swung his pipe back and forth as if the short, slightly bent piece of metal was a quarterstaff.

Catra cackled and leaped upward, landing upon the bent end of the pipe. Crouching over the now petrified young man, as she bore down upon him fangs glinting the moonlight cascading in through the broken window high above. Prepared to sink them into his throat, as he screamed and dropped the pipe. Completely unprepared for her incredible agility and speed, to effortlessly jump and perch upon the end of his makeshift club. Like some apex predator. Prepared to take down her prey without mercy. He swiftly backed up, hitting the rounded casing of a sideways resting rotter of one of the Runner's. As Catra prowled after him on all fours.

"Did you seriously think you were in control here?" She taunted smugly, a superior swagger to her loping gait. As she reared up

and pinned him down against the hover sled. Claws sunk deep into the metal on either side of his head. As her feral grin of sharp fangs gleamed with violent intent inches away from his nose.

“Please don’t hurt me…” He whimpered, raising his arms to protect his face.

Catra scoffed, “Like you Fucker’s would have giving me any kind of mercy!”

“It’s just a game…a challenge…” He countered in a pathetic gasp. Eyes flying wide, as Catra lunged with her claws. He crossed his arms over his face, expecting the attack there. But Catra slashed him across the chest, in a criss-cross. Shredding his training shirt and leaving deep gashes over his torso.

He wailed and crumpled to the ground, holding his chest and curling up into a protective ball, as blood seeped from the slashes.

“A game in which the steaks were too high and you were not prepared to win.” She snarled, kicking him brutally in the head and shoulders until he whimpered pathetically as he fell unconscious.

With a satisfied grin, Catra turned on her heel and prowled back to his companion. Finding the larger youth, sitting against the side of a crate amid the pile of scattered tools that had once laid within.

“You gotta take your boy there to the infirmary before he bleeds out?” She commanded, chucking a thumb towards the gored heap by the Runner.

“I can’t walk.” He groaned, thumping the back of his head against the crate in frustration.

Catra merely shrugged apathetically and turned on her heel to leave.

Slipping out the crack between the heavy shed doors, wary of what may lay in wait for her outside. Her movements were silent, stepping only on her toes as she slid into the darkness outside. Quickly sprinting away around the corner of the large building, to hide in the deeper shadow's there.

Only to find scattered bodies of at least ten more of her hunter's. Lying unconscious, with Adora standing over them. Heaving for breath, a long slender metal pole gripped tight in her hands. No doubt stolen from one of her defeated foes.

"What the hell…" Catra gasped in shock. She had been fighting all night, in short desperate skirmishes. Dispatching one hunting party after another, never expecting there were still so many more searching for her. It was alarming…and oddly a little flattering. That so many of their rival Senior cadets' wanted to hunt her.

Adora swiftly spun around, dropping the rod with a clatter and raced up to Catra. Her blue eyes were bright and wet with tears.

"Are you alright?" She exclaimed, pressing her hands to Catra's cheeks. As relief flooded through her. Adora's face was mere inches away from the magicats. The terror in her blue eyes instantly softened into something warm and tender.

Catra was instantly lost in the sudden affection and desperation in her eyes to know she was alright. Holding her breath, yearning for the blonde to finish her forward advance and kiss her. Catra couldn't help but focus on the plump pink of her lips, parting slightly as she drew even closer. The soft moment was so brief, it could have been no more than a stupid fantasy on Catra's part. Before Adora was lifting her arms and circling her, to ascertain her wounds. Now all clinical and on task to make sure she wasn't hurt to badly.

"I'm fine!" Catra snarled, pulling away indignantly. Hiding her disappointment behind her rage.

“Good…then let's get you to the Infirmary. Those cuts look deep.” Adora grasped her hand and pulled her forward. Their hand holding had changed over the years, it was no longer a comfort but was now a controlling action. One Adora only used when she needed Catra to comply without a fight.

“Why are you here!” Catra ripped her hand out of Adora’s grasp. Catra knew Adora had formed a group of cadet’s hell bent on stopping the hunts. But those cadets under her command only got in the way, blocking the hunter’s from leaving the barracks but never engaged in combat. So that those under her command, if caught, would not get punished.

This time though, with Catra’s well being on the line. The blonde had thrown all caution and self preservation aside. Rampaging through the Infantry Sector like the Wind of Justice taking out every cadet that got in her way. Incapacitating at least two strike teams from various squadron’s right here and no doubt even more were lying beaten and unconscious along the way here. On top of all those casualties, Catra had taken out a good number of cadets’ herself tonight. Most of the barracks Senior Squads would be in the infirmary for the next few weeks!

They were so dead! Shadow Weaver was going to kill them both now!

“I couldn’t let them hurt you!” Adora shouted back. “I had to protect you!”

“I don’t need you to protect me!” Catra raged back, fury and fear warring inside of her. Adora was going to get punished…perhaps not as severely as her. But it would still be bad. She didn’t have to do that, her need to be the hero was so infuriating!

“I….” Adora sniffed and cast her head down, concealing her tears.

“Com’on, idiot!” Catra huffed, grabbing her hand and leading her inside the shed.

Whatever…they were both all in now! Might as well face the consequences together…

"Catra…what did you do!" Adora cried in alarm, finding the two badly wounded cadet's bleeding profusely upon the dirt of the shed's floor.

"I defended myself, stupid!" Catra explained, hefting up the boy she had slash across the chest and carrying him over her shoulder like a sack.

While Adora picked up the larger boy in a fireman's carry, over her shoulder.

"You don't think you went a little overboard?" Adora commented, dryly as they walked back to the barracks carrying the wounded.

"Maybe a little." Catra smirked.

Senior Years: Part Two

Chapter Notes

> Thankyou Pink Storm for your comments! Also thanks to all who left Kudos.

Second year…

The warm season was in full swing, the sky during the evening hour's burning like it was set on fire. Which was conceivable with the amount chemical's the Fright Zone belched into the air from the Refinery. Not a single cloud marred the glowing red hue, as Adora stared up at the sky in a daze. In the quiet moment she found herself in. She was instantly consumed by her crushing anxieties. The endless spiral of dread, of not living up to Shadow Weaver's expectations. Not working hard enough, or achieving enough, or leading her Squad well enough…the list just goes on and on. So much responsibility…so much pressure…just so much….

"Hey, Adora…" Catra crooned, followed by a sweet giggle. As her teasingly mocking smile graced her face when it came into view above her, to block the red sky. Adora lay flat out on her back amid the towering piles of discarded rubbish, deep in the labyrinth of the scrapyard.
"Catra…why do you have to be such a brat!" Adora groaned, slowly rising to a seated position. Clutching her pounding head, having just stumbled off the peak of a garbage pile in pursuit of a very stubborn, very obstante magicat. Who refused to follow even the simplest of order's! She was starting to regret making her second in command of the Squad. All she did was argue with her and make her look like a fool!

She had just lost her footing a second ago, tried to brace herself on a dented piece of a mutation turret , only to have the rounded

hull slip sideways out from beneath her. Leaving her flapping her arms and tumbling head first down the pile of debris, like a doofus. Smacking her head hard against a cannon mussel jutting out near the bottom.

Now she was bleeding from the temple and had a pounding headache. With a moan, she pressed her fingertips to the scratch drawing them back finding blood. The wound wasn't deep and it would scab quickly enough.

“You're the dummy that followed me up there?” Catra braced her hands on her hips in indignation.

“Because you're being too reckless and you're going to get us caught!” Adora exclaimed. The ramparts of the infantry sector faced the scrapyard so if they climbed too high the sentries would be able to spot them easily. Sneaking out of the barracks was getting increasingly harder as they got older. When they were kids the guards on patrol never seemed to catch them. Or perhaps they just didn’t care as much. It was plausible little kids were more disposable and less valuable then almost fully trained soldiers.

“What are you looking for out here anyway?” Adora sighed, taking Catra’s hand as she offered it. Allowing the magicat to pull her up to her feet.

“None of your business, I never wanted you to follow me out here anyway.” Catra retorted with her usual caustic snark. Crossing her arms of her chest as her tail swung back and forth defiantly.

“No, one leaves the barracks alone! It’s an order.” Adora confronted her.

“Yeah, one of your stupid order’s…Squad Leader.” Catra shot back, heatedly.

“I just want to keep everyone safe!” Adora scowled at her, as she kept pace beside the feline who was moving at a crisp jog. Ducking and weaving through the debris of rusted out tank hulls

and gutted cargo transports. Going ever deeper into the forgotten wreckage of the munition graveyard of the Fright Zone.

“If you didn't want me following you, you should have taken someone with you.” Adora reiterated in a huffy breath.

Catra’s scowl deepened, who could she ask anyway. Everyone hated her!

“Like Lonnie..” Adora offered, helpfully.

“She’s a bitch, I doubt I could control myself if I spent any time alone with her. It's a good bet I’d kill her…the scrapyard is a great place to hide a body...don’t you think.!” Catra spat back with a teasing smirk, her tone thick with dark sarcasm.

Adora blinked at her for a moment totally appalled then quickly schooled her expression knowing that Catra was just kidding… hopefully.

“Kyle?” Adora shrugged.

“That loser would fall flat on his face, crossing the street. Adora… We would get caught before we even got to the gates .” Catra rolled her eyes. “Then we would both be locked up in solitary for a week…I’d sooner die than be in a cell next to his and have to listen to him whine and snivel for hours on end.”

Adora merely nodded, totally understanding.

“How about Rogelio?” She finally offered.

“He doesn’t talk…I doubt he even understands what we say to him half the time?” Catra remarked smartly.

“That would make sense…he screws up rather frequently during our holo scenarios if the combat strategy is too complex…” Adora mussed.

Over the years the squadron had been broken up into only two strike teams. So she and Catra spent a great deal more time with Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio during a typical training day. Then with the rest of the Squadron in which they only had morning drills. They might see a few of them in some of the classes, but those learning blocks were filled with cadets from other squads as well.

It was a good hike across the junkyard that was several miles long. Until they came across the gutted hull of a Taser class, blast tank. The wide treads were stripped, leaving only the rusted rounded hubcaps and gears under the massive sharply angled hull. The rounded turret was still intact but the cannon was gone. What was left was just a sad, broken shell, useless and discarded. Left to rust in the elements and slowly decay. A perfect den that Catra had been using for almost a year now. Catra had several den's over the years scattered throughout the Fright Zone. Where she would hide out when she needed a break from people. Hoarding the treasures that she found or stole from other cadets or even senior officers. Mostly it was contraband food that the Soldiers smuggled in when they returned from missions beyond the Fright Zones borders.

Taking Adora to her new den had been her plan all along, knowing that she would follow her. If Catra allowed her to…

Catra cast Adora a smug smile over her shoulder, before sprinting for the busted tank. Leaping up onto the narrow manifold above the naked wheels and climbing effortlessly up onto the top of the turret. Slipping gracefully inside the open hatch.

Adora finally caught on.

"You led me here on purpose!" She shouted, scrambling after Catra.

They had been fighting more than getting along for months now. Catra hated it! She wanted to reclaim that close unburdened friendship they once had and leave the rivalry of the barracks behind. So she decided to show Adora her new hideout, hoping to

shift their dynamic at least for a little while. She needed to know she still mattered, at least to Adora. She had been feeling far too hopeless and adrift lately. Adora had become so focused on her goals, single minded and determined to become the best soldier. Losing sight of what truly mattered, losing sight of her own needs. Working herself into the ground to live up to Shadow Weaver's glorified expectations of her. She was becoming obsessed with perfection, driven to control every part of her life and everyone in it! The squad was on edge around her, it wasn't bad enough they had their Drill Sergeant and Lazlo breathing down their necks to improve. Adora had changed as well, no longer was she their cheerleader. Pushing them to succeed as they trained. Her words become as sharp and unforgiving as Shadow Weaver's. Calling them all out on their faults and accusing them of not living up to their potential. Adora's opinion of her, had soured to the point it had become a perfect copy to Shadow Weaver's. Parroting the old hag's words, that she was disrespectful...lazy...and unmotivated. She was scared, how much Adora had changed. The growing need to fix the downward trajectory of their friendship had become the most important mission to her. She was terrified they would become even more distant…or worse…grow to truly hate one another. Also...she was the Squadron's Second in Command, it was her duty to smack some sense into their 'Squad Leader.' Physically, if she had too. So she was also preparing herself to have a long, rather uncomfortable talk with Adora.

Dropping into the shadowed compartment, Catra quickly surveyed her modified interior. Catra had unbolted the hard plastic gunner's seat and tossed it out. Filling the tiny circular cavity with anything soft she could find. Which wasn't much.

She had stuffed the metal gap, where the gunner seat had been with foam, covered with blankets. A few large towels from the communal showers, balled up in the corners as pillows.

Keeping the two hard plastic round stools, for the tank commander and engineer on either side of the cockpit. Where the end of the gun mount should have been attached to the cannon

outside was empty space. Leaving a nice skylight like hole up in the center of the turret cavity roof.

She had stuffed a crate full of contraband between the two seats. She had been stealing items for several weeks so that she would have some kind of variety to offer.

When Adora slipped inside through the hatch, Catra commanded her to close it behind her. Adora nodded sealing the top of the turret before clambering down into her own seat across from Catra.

Catra vision in the near darkness was remarkable. She took her seat on a stool, leaning over the side to plug in a cord, instantly a string of tiny light bulbs strung along the top of the dome, flared to life. Casting the sealed compartment in a brilliant yellow light.

“New Den?” Adora commented, she has been led to several hidden holes over the years that Catra had claimed as her own. When she was little, they had been tucked away into the ductwork of the barracks. Or a makeshift fort built at the back of the equipment shed. This by far was the most extravagant of her dens.

“So you were planning on bringing me here all along?” Adora smirked, pushing her shoulder fondly.

“Yeah, don’t make a big deal of it!” Catra snapped back, leaning down and digging into the crate to hide her blush.

“I’m not.” Adora sighed, defensively. Avoiding looking at her too, by slowly taking in their surroundings. Catra had made this place so cozy! With the little bunk in the corner and what looked like, a string of tiny lights strung up along the roof. They glowed like little sparks of light, illuminating the shadowed cab in a soft, twinkling light.

“How are you powering those…is the engine still functional…did you wire them into the core?” Adora was amazed by Catra’s ingenuity.

“Does it matter, Doofus.” Catra griped, finally pulling out a bottle and a package or two items wrapped in cloth.

“Awww….is this a picnic?” Adora cooed, her blue eyes warm with long held affection towards the cat-girl.

“NO, Dumb Ass…It’s an intervention so shut up and listen.” Catra snarled, tossing her the bottle. “Take a drink, cause I am not going to pull my punches, 'Squad Leader'.” The tone she used when addressing Adora’s title had been snide and sarcastic, as if she no longer deserved any respect.

Adora caught the bottle, mouth hanging open in surprise. Catra rarely, if ever, talked to her so bluntly. Always deflecting serious conversations with dark humor or merely running away to avoid hashing things out. Leaving what was bothering her to fester until she lashed out at someone on the squad, or a random cadet that crossed her path at the wrong time. Getting herself locked into solitary for a few days to cool down.

Adora wiggled the cork and eventually pulled it out and took a small, tentative sip. The golden liquid inside burned her throat all the way down, leaving the hacking and pounding her chest to alleviate the searing pain.

“What the hell is this?” Adora railed.

“Don’t know, Don’t care, it gets the job done. Makes me feel better when I feel shitty, so I figure since I am about to make you feel real shitty, it's going to cushion the blow.” Catra shrugged, she had wallowed many times in a bottle like that over the last few years.

“Just take it slow, cause you’ll feel even worse in the morning if you pound it back. I know from experience.” Catra tagged on, opening one of the cloth packages. Revealing some strange looking dark squares and two mysterious packets of biscuits.

“Where do you even get these contraband?” Adora mused, holding the bottle away from herself, as if it was a bomb about to

go off.

“Again, does it matter! I want to share it, so just enjoy it with me. Can you just fucking relax...for once. ” Catra rolled her eyes.

“I know…I’m sorry, you’re right.” Adora groaned, taking a more cautious sip of the bottle prepared for the burn this time.

They were silent for a time, as Catra opened the packets pulling out several round wafer’s that looked like golden ration bars? Then broke the large dark square into smaller bits. Then she divided the morsel’s up between them in two clear plastic containers.

“Give me the bottle.” Catra demanded, as soon as Adora was picking at the strange food in her lap.

The blonde absently offered her the bottle. Picking it up off the floor by the neck, where she had set it down, when Catra had passed her the food. All while nibbling on a round wafer. It was sweet and very tasty. She hummed happily, as Catra took a long swallow of the vibrant liquid. Before wiping her mouth with her wrist and taking a deep breath.

“What’s wrong with you?” She accused, tone snide and completely disgusted by Adora’s recent behavior.

“What do you mean?” Adora mumbled around a mouthful. Oblivious to Catra’s feelings, in her mind she had done nothing wrong. She had been acting in a manner that was completely alright, since she was in command.

“You’ve been riding the squad pretty hard lately.” Catra commented tactfully, as she offered her bottle. Taking a new approach, since Adora wasn’t getting it.

“What do you mean?” Adora took the bottle, feigning ignorance. Knowing full well she had been rather harsh with everyone. But it was for their own good, they needed to improve. She would do

whatever was necessary to make sure Red Squad stayed on top of the rankings.

Catra stared at her in disbelief. "You made me your second for a reason, Adora. Because you knew I'd always tell the truth, that I would call you on your bullshit!"

"Look, I'm getting tough…I get it. But we need to do better, we need to be better!" Adora explained, rolling her eyes in disregard.

"No, you're being a total Ass! To Everyone!" Catra spat back.

Adora was silently brooding, now as she took another sip.

"Our stats are satisfactory, Adora. What more do you want?" Catra hadn't touched her food, while Adora had been packing it away at light speed and was almost done.

"I want us to be the best! I will not suffer mediocrity from the squad any longer!" Adora grumbled back, taking a long swallow from the bottle. She was feeling warm inside and her head felt a little fuzzy. Completely oblivious how much like Shadow Weaver she sounded.

"Your expectations are too high! You're acting like Shadow Weaver!" Catra spat back, yanking the bottle away from her for another drink.

"How is that a bad thing?" Adora corrected, "She's our commander, she knows how to motivate the troops…I'm merely following her example…cause it gets things done!" Adora explained, tears welling up in her eyes. Her bowed shoulders and downcast eyes told otherwise though. She was ashamed of how she had been treating everyone, because secretly she hated being treated that way by that old hag. Adora was quick to conceal her weakness, her repenting expression stiffening to an impassive stone mask. With a growl Adora snatched the bottle back and took another drink. Their conversation was intense, without the soothing effect of this liquid. She felt she may have been

overwhelmed already, either screaming back at Catra or else crying like a stupid little kid.

"Lately, you're not around after training, Adora. All you do is scream and put us all down for being inferior to you all day. Then disappear until light out with Shadow Weaver for extra 'tutoring'. You don't see the mess you leave each day." Catra growled.

Adora took another drink.

"You made Kyle cry a couple days ago." Catra accused softly, pressing her hands between her knees. "He wasn't the pathetic, whimpering, sniffling loser in the corner of his bunk he usually is when he's stressed out. He was all out bawling, loud and ugly. He sounded like someone was ripping him apart from the inside out, he was in real pain! Adora! and it was all your fault. "

Adora took another drink. This was all her fault…but she didn't know what to do anymore...Kyle had been holding them back for years...if he didn't keep up…and graduate with the rest of them… Adora shook her head, seeking to clear away the brutal thoughts about what may happen to Kyle… if he failed…if he was proven to be useless too the Horde.

"Lonnie's been trying really hard, but she's stopped eating. Which means she is only going to get more tired and more unfocused during scenarios. Rogelio's checked out, have you even noticed. It's like he's given up! Our stats are going to tank as a Strike team if this keeps up." Catra turned, her face was flushed and her eyes were burning with rage and unshed tears. She acted like she didn't care about her squad mates, but she did. She would only show it to Adora in private.

Adora took another drink…hating herself.

Silence reigned for a long time, as Catra picked at her food. Allowing the brutal truth of her words to sink in.

"When the squad doesn't meet Shadow Weaver's expectations…As the Squad Leader…I have to pay the consequences. " Adora

mumbles, after years of denying it, of defecting about what had been happening during her ‘private tutoring’. Adora finally caved and told Catra the truth….sort of…anyway.

Catra, always thought she was the only one being punished for not meeting that wretched hag’s expectations?

“How.” Catra croaked out, her voice barely a whisper.

Adora shrugged, “Depends on how badly the squad performs.” She shrugs avoiding the question, not wanting to voice the rather inventive ways the sorceress has ‘tutored’ her over the years. All in the name of instilling obedience, perfection and a ruthlessness to always prevail no matter the consequences to herself or anyone else.

Catra took the bottle from her and took a long drink. The revelation that Adora was being hurt in the same ways as her was horrific to know.

"She has been ‘tutoring’ you nightly for the last few weeks?’ Catra grunted.

Adora grunted back in acknowledgment.

Catra took another drink.

“I admit, I have been rather hard on everyone lately. But I was only trying to get us to improve….so she didn’t have to ‘tutor’ me as harshly.” Adora confessed.

Catra took another drink.

“She sucks, so much.” Catra huffed.

“That she does…” Adora, leaned back. Resting the back of her head against the hull. Her posture was so deflated, with her shoulders slumped and head craned back. Her eyes were closed and the soft glow of the lights made her look so fragile. Like a fine piece of porcelain, delicately beautiful but easily shattered. Catra

wanted to reach out and hold her, confess that Shadow Weaver hurts her too, has for years. But she held her tongue instead and took another drink. The lulling effect of the alcohol was starting to get to her as well.

Her muscles felt so loose, like jelly. With a giggle she slipped sideways onto the soft mattress she made on the floor in the nook, where the gunner's seat once was. Making sure the bottle stayed upright, not willing to dump the precious contents. While her treats that had been in her lap scattered over the cockpit floor, as Adora moaned sadly as they were ruined.

"I would have eaten those." Adora pouted.

"Get over here, dummy." Catra patted the mattress beside her invitingly.

Adora acquiesced, releasing a long breath and then crawled down beside her.

They laid on their sides, facing each other, propping themselves up on their elbows. Sharing the rest of the bottle in companionable silence. Each one reflecting upon the hard conversation they had just had. When it was empty, Catra leaned over Adora, her movements were slow and exaggerated as if she had to concentrate real hard to maintain her balance. Sluggishly let go of the bottle, allowing it to topple over and roll away under the plastic stool in the far corner of the hull.

"How do I fix things?" Adora finally spoke, falling onto her back and crossing her arms behind her head. There was far more to that statement left unsaid. How did she make Shadow Weaver happy and their squad happy at the same time?

"I don't know." Catra rolled onto her back as well. "I've learned to take each day as it comes. Most of'em are going to be bad, I've accepted that. I deal. "

Adora moaned, she rarely heard Catra speak so morbidly. The feline was always so fiery and full of spite back in the barracks.

Acting like she was better than all the rest, that she was untouchable.

“This is bullshit.” Adora roared, with a slurred enunciation. Punching the side of the hull in her building rage. The dull, echoing sound reverberated around them. Catra smirked, her ear’s flattening back and tail thumping aggressively against the mattress.

“It’s us or them, always has been.” Catra advised, her speech was slurred and her sentence structure was awkward.

“I….” Adora was shocked by her assessment.

“What would really happen to them if we left?” Catra mussed, wistfully. “We could just keep on going. Sneak out of the base and head somewhere…anywhere just the two of us.”

“That’s not a solid plan.” Adora chuckled. Leaning onto her side and brushing a finger tip down Catra’s mask.

Catra gasped, sliding her eyes towards Adora. Her heart was beating fast in her chest and she was nervous about where that soft touch was going to lead them.

“Should we just stay and let Shadow Weaver hurt us for another two years.” Catra muttered, her eyes searching Adora’s. A hopeful yearning for more, clear in her wet gaze.

Adora sucked in a breath.

“She hurts you too…”

“Duh! She’s been ‘tutoring’ me for years too, Adora.” Catra mocked her. The stupid blonde was so oblivious...what the hell had they been talking about? 'Tutoring’ had been code between them for the terrible thing’s Shadow Weaver did to them in private…right?

“I guess I’ve always known it…I just refused to believe it was happening.” Adora muttered falling back onto her back.

“I hate it here.” Catra confessed.

“So do, I. ” Adora admitted.

“Then let’s leave…tonight!” Catra was all fired up, she sprang forward leaning over Adora’s chest. Her actions were bold and no longer under her better judgment. As her face was now inches away from Adora’s.

Adora smiled softly up at her, cupping her cheek.

“I missed this….I missed you.” She confessed, in a breathy hush.

Catra swallowed, leaning forward just a bit closer. Her eyes seek out Adora’s, gauging her reaction. With her heart in her throat and her feelings more than apparent she closed the distance when Adora did not pull back.

Pressing her lips against Adora’s, in a short, tentative kiss.

When Catra pulled back, worried she had changed things forever between them with her impulsiveness. Finding the blonde out cold, snoring…

Catra groaned and rolled her eyes in disappointment.

“Perhaps it’s for the best…I never get what I want anyway.” She sniffled, settling down upon Adora’s soft chest and curling her smaller body up against the blonde. Quickly falling asleep with a heavy heart. Accepting whatever crumbs of affection and acceptance she was given from her ‘best friend.’

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Things had changed after that, at least for Catra. Adora didn't seem to remember much of that night. Besides Catra's harsh opinion of her leadership skills, or lack thereof. Either way she had gotten through and Adora had changed her tactics. Returning back to her more kind approach to positively drive the squad than reprimand. Morale improved and so did overall performance but not by much.

Kyle was still Kyle…

Adora just dealt with Shadow Weaver in silence, just as Catra did. They never spoke about it again.

Catra found herself staring at Adora, in the quiet moments after lights out. Watching her sleep, guarding her from the foot of her bed as she had done for many years now. Lingering in the showers, curious about how Adora's body may look unclothed. Never really getting a very good look through\. In the brief time she had, trying to be discrete, while toweling her own body and hair just outside the open tile stalls. Before discretion and perhaps a bit of fear, she would trail after the rest of the female members of their squad back to the locker room to change. Adora's smiles affected her so much more now. Making her chest ache and stomach flip, with a yearning she didn't fully understand. She just wanted to be close to her all the time! Yet, getting too close meant weakness…it meant pain…so she quickly pushed those feelings away and hid her wants behind her sassy attitude. That always took on an antagonistic attitude, with just a dash of a teasing quality in her interactions with Adora. That was their dynamic…and she held onto it like a life preserver.

Senior Years: Part Three

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Pink Storm for your comments and all those who have left Kudo's. Here's the last Chapter enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Third year…

"Well, you really 'Kyled' up our entrance." Catra commented bitterly while shaking her head. Scowling down at Adora from an upper rung of a rusted out ladder, that was barely bolted onto the side of a worn, brick and mortar warehouse.
While Adora glanced upward, offering her a scowl of irritation , all her own. From her vantage point on a lower rung of the ladder. She had lost her footing, unable to keep up the same rapid climbing pace as Catra. She had stopped watching where her feet were landing, focused only on keeping up. Resulting in her slamming her boot down on a rusted out piece of rung, then having it clatter all the way down, rebounding off the side of the water tank on the ground. The ringing clang of metal on tin, echoed like a thunderclap throughout the shipping complex.
The fire team was on a mock recon and retrieval mission. To infiltrate an enemy compound and steal secret documents for Horde intelligence. They had been briefed that morning, given only a half hour to gather up their spy equipment and weapons before being thrown into enemy territory. Which was the industrial district of the Fright Zone. Full of factories and warehouses, that churned out everything from ration bars, building materials, vehicles, weapons and bots. Everything the Horde needed in day-to day life inside the fortress to survive and all the equipment and weapons the army needed to conquer Etheria.
Adora had very limited time to plan, which was sending her stress level through the roof. Catra was far more calm, strategizing on the fly as they navigated through the narrow alleys between the stout, multi leveled factories. Ducking and weaving through the

maze of outlying, shipping warehouses. While Adora relayed her instructions, through their com badges as if they were her own. Sending Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio to their designated positions to watch their backs, as they snuck into the four story brick building. Heading up a fire escape, then onto a flimsy ladder. up to the cracked and broken, green tinted windows on the top floor, that was going to be their infiltration point.

They had scouted out the industrial area earlier, with a spy drone. Their rival fire team was holding up on the top floor of this munition's warehouse. So since, Catra and Adora made a perfect duo, able to move and anticipate each other's tactics. They were sent to retrieve the plan's, while Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio took cover around the warehouse to cover their retreat.
Catra's ears pinned back, as she heard abrupt movement from inside. With a hiss she leaped to the side, off the ladder and scrambled through a broken out window. Adora cursed and quickly followed her same haphazard route inside the dark interior of the warehouse. They were improvising now, dammit!

****

Three days had passed since Red Squads final yearly trail. Louis was dead and everyone was at odds with each other worse than ever. Sara was withdrawn, while Atila became a volatile bomb of rage and unfocused aggression. The bunkroom had new dents in the walls from his fists and their back door to the training yard was currently ripped off its hinges. Didn't matter, no one really cared. It was the hot season and the cool draft at night was welcome. Otis had stopped talking, no one knew if he was eating either. Always taking off before morning roll call and returning just after lights out. Which was totally understandable, his best friend was gone. Levi and Max had taken up a new project out in the scrap yard and never even came back to their barracks for the last few days. The trio, Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio had tried to keep the squad's spirits up. Bouncing from group to group with encouragement and a kind ear to listen to whatever they wanted to talk about, or just hang out with them in silence. As they all grieved in their own ways.

Catra had retreated to her rooftop platform near the forge, days ago and never came down. Cutting herself off from everyone… even from Adora.
Who didn't seem to notice, the magicat was missing this time. As she had just simply checked out. Lost in her own head, consumed by her failure as their Squad Leader. Her command belt and red jacket lay discarded, in a crumpled heap in the bottom of her locker. Where she had tossed them after their last trail, in a fit of rage. She had punched her locker door several times, denting and warping it until it no longer even closed. Before storming out of the locker room.
Days later, Sara would cross her path near the entrance to the Great Hall. Which was not uncommon. Adora idolized the heroes of the Horde, immortalized down the Great Hall in plaques and photographs. She would pace up and down the wide hallway, memorizing each hero's heroic deeds enshrined below their pictures. Her pacing outside the Great Hall so distraught and agitated was not normal. Sara held her breath and hid behind a junction vent on the other side of the corridor. Not brave enough to approach. Too stunned and wary of Adora's completely unhinged behavior and barely put together appearance. Her white and gray tank top hung half untucked from her gray pants, the cloth under her bare arms stained from sweat. No doubt she had been working out pretty much non-stop since the accident. Adora was muttering to herself, pacing up and down the narrow corridor, with a data pad in her hand. A distant, haunted look in her eyes. As she read and reread all her notes, about the mock battle for their trail. Trying to figure out where she had gone wrong, what small detail she might have missed in the mission debrief, that could have prevented Louis from being killed. Her once well manicured appearance was in shambles. She looked rough and disheveled. Her greasy blonde hair was in disarray from constantly running her fingers through it. The high ponytail now hung loose, her poof was gone and her bangs were a flyaway mess around her face. Sara had never seen their leader look so out of control.
Lonnie caught sight of her later that same day, having gone up to the infantry sector ramparts for a bit of peace and quiet away from the barracks. She watched Adora run for miles throughout

the training sector all by herself. Drenched in sweat and out of breath from pushing herself beyond her limits.
Kyle noticed her just after supper, when he passed the locker rooms. Punching and kicking at the sandbag. Scowling and grunting as her fists struck the heavy bag, in some endless rage fueled crescendo. Recklessly her hands were unbandaged and she was bleeding from her knuckles. Leaving smears of blood across the leather skin of the bag. From then on the squad would report an Adora sighting amongst themselves but no one had the guts to ever approach her.
All her years of pent up rage were now boiling up to the surface. Her once warm blue eyes had become hard as steel. Moving through the corridor's with swift strides. Her body coiled like a weapon about to strike, fists clenched and boots stomping. Alerting everyone else to stay the fuck out of her way. She never said a word to anyone, she was a phantom now, appearing and disappearing at random.

Shadow Weaver never interfered, skulking in the shadow's of Adora's wake. As Adora brooded around the barracks. The young woman had such a threatening aura around her now. Even the Sorceress had become cautious, knowing how volatile she was. Now was not the time for her to offer advice. She had enough sense of self preservation not to confront Adora. The young woman had such raw, untapped magical power. This 'tragic' event may be the catalyst that finally unlocked her full potential. So the Sorceress watched and she waited…eager to step in when the time was right. To redirect Adora's wrath in the proper direction… She always had her sights set on gaining more power, on taking the throne of the Horde away from Hordak. Adora was her ultimate weapon, easily manipulated and conditioned to obey. She just needed to be triggered…and then pointed at the Sorceresses chosen targets.
The unity of the squad was shattered and it seemed there was no way to mend the fragmented pieces into something useful ever again. Which was unfortunate but not unsalvageable. But Adora didn't need them anymore, she needed to learn to let go of her attachments to her squad and move on. She was destined for so

much more than just being their leader…she had a greater purpose to fulfill.
The sorceress white eyes narrowed in scrutiny, behind her mask. Deciding at that moment to amputate the squad from Adora, the first chance she got. They had served their purpose to mold her into a leader…someone the Horde would idolize and look up to as the war effort intensified. She would make a fine Force Captain and with her, under Shadow Weaver's control. She would usurp Hordak and become the new leader of the Horde.
She was a child of Destiny! If she could control her…she could control destiny itself!
Shadow Weaver would have as much power she had always craved, pulling the strings of the Horde through Adora. She would be able to crush anyone who opposed her! Nothing was beyond her reach as long as she had Adora!

The night sky was a blank void, four greater Moon's hung heavy with their smaller counterparts scattered over the lower horizon beyond the macabre tower's of the fortress. It was only a few hours until the Day Moon would ascend once again.
Catra had returned to the bunkroom, climbing the chain link fence to their outer training yard. Leaning against the tin wall just outside the open doorway, refusing to go inside. Lonnie sat just inside the door, holding a crudely drawn map on a piece of paper, in her hand. That she had drawn from memory. Memories long buried and blurred from her childhood before the Fright Zone. She was a foundling, brought in during the first year of training by a naval recon team near Scorpion Hills.
"So where do you think you were from?" Catra asked, glancing down at Lonnie briefly. Maintaining her aloof posture and bored tone, as if her answer really didn't matter all that much.
"Somewhere in Salineas, I guess." Lonnie shrugged. " I have pictures in my head, snapshots of my life before the Horde. Weird tall trees with huge canopies of dark green leaves and sandy beaches…there was a graveyard…high up in the hills hidden inside the woods. It was a beautiful place. With tall marker's, names etched in stone with an ancient shrine…my mom used to take them there. "

“What’s a shrine?’ Kyle asked, he was sitting beside Lonnie. Knees pressed up against his chest.
“A holy place…with buildings. In the center of a grand inner courtyard, with these large open gateways to enter the shrine. It was where my village would go. To pray and we would have a festival for the dead…once a year to honor all those who had already crossed over to the Eternal Realm.”
Kyles eyes flew wide in horror.
“It wasn’t creepy…it was…it was…” Lonnie was struggling to find the right words.
“It was comforting…we told stories about the family member’s who died and laughed and feasted on so much great food.” She grew quiet for a second.
“So many memories?” Lonnie finished, blinking away stray tears she couldn’t stop from rolling down her dark cheeks.
“Happy ones.” Catra pointedly inquired, unable to mask the resentment she felt.
“Better ones, yeah…but also some really bad ones too.” Lonnie sighed heavily. “I don’t know…I always blamed the Horde for destroying my village...but now after living here for so long. That doesn’t seem right. The Horde can’t even reach Salineas, because of the Sea Gate. So blaming the Horde for burning down my village makes no sense...When all I remember is fire…being adrift in a boat for days…with other people…then Horde Soldier’s wrapping up the dead in blankets…so I wouldn’t see… and a Horde Soldier taking my hand and leading me to a transport.” Lonnie, pressed her palm against her forehead. Squeezing her eyes shut to block out the horrible fragments of her past.
“Yeah…I have no memories besides Adora finding me.” Catra slid down the wall to sit on the ground, leaning heavily against the doorway. This was the closest to a heart to heart she had ever had with Lonnie.
It was nice…but strange. They were never close, Catra had purposefully kept her distance from the rest of her squad mates since Tama. She just couldn’t handle losing someone close to her again, her heart was already cracked. She knew if she lost someone else she held dear it would break completely.

By the time Adora returned to the bunk room dawn was less than an hour away. She had showered and changed into fresh underclothes. Her hair was still damp and hanging over her shoulders. Moving silently through the slowly hissing doors into her squad's dark sleeping quarters. Greeted, to low, conspiratorial whispers from the back door.
“What’s going on?” She inquired, tossing her damp towel from around her neck to her bunk. As she walked down the aisle between bed racks to the cluster of squad mates huddled at the back. Glancing sideways as she noticed Otis curled up under his blankets on his lower bunk, an odd tentacle sticking out beyond the fabric. By the slow rise and fall of the blanket, he was finally fast asleep.
The pale green lighting from their quarter’s industrial, caged, wall lamps cast an eerie glow over the hushed room.
The huddled group of cadet’s at the back, instantly fell quiet at her approach. Adora scanned each one briefly, with a tactical eye. Judging the varying emotions that passed between each one and their level of threat. Sara and Atila as always were aloof, leaning against the back corner of the room next to each other. They had been listening to their squad mates' little meeting but not engaging with them.
The rest were all sitting on the floor, hunched over something set in the middle of them. None of them were dressed for bed, still wearing their training clothes. Lonnie was the only one brave enough to look up and acknowledge her entrance into their midst. Her hazel eyes were hard, resolved when she met Adora’s inquiring gaze.
“We’re leaving.” She spat bluntly.
Adora was shocked at first, blue eyes wide then slowly narrowing. “When…why…” she sputtered., glancing sideways, to find several survival packs fully loaded and leaning against the open back door.
“Tonight, because our friends deserve better than being tossed inside a furnace.” Levi spat, brushing her long black bangs off her face in frustration. Only to have her heavy fringe fall back into

place a second later.
“That’s not true…who told you that?” Adora railed, her breath suddenly constricting in panic.
“I did.” Catra answered, prowling out of the shadow’s that had once concealed her out in the back training yard. She leaned against the doorframe, arms crossed. Still dressed in her red tunic and ripped, maroon leggings. Mask firmly in place upon her brow and a fearsome scowl on her face.
“That’s not true, Catra…you're lying.” Adora moved briskly over to the door, gripping Catra by the shoulders, completely appalled that she would make up such a gruesome lie. Just to get everyone riled up enough to mutiny against the Horde. She was being reckless with all their lives. If they were caught trying to leave… Adora’s chest clenched in dread and the muscles burned with sudden fright.
“So what if I am.” Catra rolled Adora’s hands off her shoulders and moved out of the doorway and back into the humid night. “Does it even matter? They’re gone…Tama, Ami, Aaron, Bryson and now Louis…they’re all gone. We just expected to just forget they never existed. Just go on with our lives as if they didn’t matter?” She ranted, tears welling in the corner of her eyes. Glaring accusingly at Adora’s as if she was at fault for their deaths.
“We don’t know what happened to Tama or Ami or Arron…they might not be dead.” Adora was adamant, following after her. Seeking as always to calm her down, control her before she got herself into trouble.
Catra scoffed, she had kept the dark secret of how Tama’s body had been disposed of until tonight. She was not going to waste her breath trying to convince the “Hordes best soldier’ how utterly evil this place was.
“Look, Adora, all we want to do is get out there. Pay proper respects to those we have lost…maybe we come back…maybe we don’t. Either way you can’t stop us.” Lonnie grasped her shoulder briefly as she passed by her through the doorway. One back already on her back and carrying another in her hand.
Adora watched in shock as Rogelio and Kyle followed her with their packs. Heading towards the chain link fence. Catra stopped at the chain link fence, taking the pack Lonnie offered her and

then slipping over her shoulders. Securing the heavy weight on her back with the buckled straps.
Adora swallowed hard, beads of sweat now rolling down from her temples as barely hung onto her panic. As cold, heart rending realizations took hold of her. Catra was going to leave…without her…without even telling her!
Adora's whole body was shivering, as if a live wire had just ignited inside of her guts.
"Ok….I'm coming with you!" She shouted, racing into the bunk room to pack her own bag.
Levi and Max were standing in the doorway as she turned.
"Your transportation is prepped and ready to go in the scrapyard. We parked by Catra's latest den." Levi tossed Adora a set of Skiff keys. Adora caught them, as she headed back to her bunk.
"How…When did you two loser's find it!" Catra scoffed, darting back to the doorway.
"Where do you think we've been 'sleeping'? When we didn't show up at curfew this week?" Max smirked, waggling his eyebrows salaciously.
"The mattress you made is pretty soft, Cat." Levi remarked, leaning suggestively up against Max. They were best friends with benefits, the whole squad had known it for years.
Catra huffed and choked on her own spit, as bile and a bit of vomit came up her throat. Her lips curled in utter disgust. Knowing by Max and Levi's lurid expression they had defiled her den multiple times this year without telling her. Confirming her own suspicions when she had smelled them the last time she hid out in the tank cockpit. She had been sleeping in that filth…she had kissed Adora on that mattress…urghhhh! Her stomach flipped with revulsion.
"Payback is coming." Catra promised, pointing a claw threateningly at each of them before turning away and sauntering out the doorway. Her tail was lashing high in fury.
"This is what you two have been working on out there for the last few days." Adora was in awe, having retreated back to her bunk. She was swiftly stuffing her survival pack with clothes and camping supplies. Realizing that Max and Levi had been planning to leave for a long time.

“Max and I were planning to make a run for it actually, before graduation. But I think this is for a better cause. Just make sure you find them a nice resting place and make a decent looking marker, Kay.” Max smiled sadly, holding Levi close with an arm around her waist.
Adora nodded, as they moved aside to allow her to slip back outside. She pocketed the key’s in her gray pants.
“We’ll hold the retrieval team off if we have to, hopefully we just need to cover for you all until you get back.” Sara called to them from the doorway. As they climbed the chain link fence and disappeared into the gray pre-dawn of the main infantry yard.

Chapter End Notes

The next part will be their adventure beyond the Fright Zone, trying to survive in the desolation the lay between the Fortress and Scorpion Hills.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!